

FOURTH SERIES
VOL. 130
No. 9



TUESDAY
4TH NOVEMBER, 2025

PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

FORMAL COMMUNICATION BY THE SPEAKER— [Col. 1]

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 12]

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS—

Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture— [Col. 38]

STATEMENTS—

(a) Introduction of HPV Vaccine in Ghana— [Col. 74]

(b) Transforming Urban Ghana: Evidence-Based Solutions for Sustainable, Clean, and Resilient Cities— [Col. 84]

ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 126]

Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

BOUND VOLUMES of the Official Report (each with a comprehensive Index) are published periodically during the Session. There is no fixed subscription rate, but prices will be quoted on each publication.

*Published by the Office of Chamber Reporting
Parliament House, Osu, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by the Publishing Department
Parliament House, Osu, Accra.*

©2025 Parliament of Ghana

THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Tuesday, 4th November, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 2:55 p.m.*

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN
SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN, IN
THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

The Speaker: Hon Members, we will take item numbered 5, Formal Communication by the Speaker.

**FORMAL COMMUNICATION BY
THE SPEAKER**

The Speaker: Hon Members, when we commenced this Meeting on 21st October, 2025, I had cause to remind Members about the need for comportment and my intention to ensure strict compliance with the 1992 Constitution and the Standing Orders of Parliament. While Hon Members are granted several privileges and immunities, which serve as procedural safeguards, these are intended to assist Members to undertake their duties and not expected to be a basis for Members to be shielded from the effects of alleged unlawful actions.

The report of attacks on a team from the National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS), a task force which we all know, has been

established to combat illegal mining activities in the country, is most worrying.

Also worrying is the fact that the attack was allegedly incited by one of our own, the Member of Parliament for Asutifi North Constituency, Mr Ebenezer Kwaku Addo, who further ropes in a Senior Member of this House, Mr Collins Dauda. While I am yet to be fully briefed on the matter, I want to take this opportunity to condemn in no uncertain terms, the attack on a team of security officers who have been assigned to help deal with the menace of *galamsey*, which has to be dealt with robustly. Nobody has denied the attack and we must all condemn that attack. The people of Ghana look to this House as a beacon of hope and it is our collective duty to set a standard that reflects the values of our great nation.

I want, once again to take the opportunity of this formal communication, to remind all of you that our actions and inactions carry immense power, effect and impact on Ghanaians and the world at large.

I have therefore instructed the Office of the Clerk and the Legal Services Office to provide all the needed support to the investigation by the Ghana Police Service within the framework of the 1992 Constitution, the laws of this country and the Standing Orders of the House

I am made to understand that the Member has voluntarily submitted himself to the Criminal Investigation Department of the Ghana Police to assist in the investigation, as many Members have done in other cases under investigation. In fact, there are so many Members of Parliament that are under investigation and my office has never shielded any Member of Parliament. Many have volunteered themselves, without coming through my office. So, please let it not be said anywhere that Members of Parliament are being shielded from the rule of law; not at all. I have copies and a list of the Members involved.

3.05 p.m.

So, while I commend this action of the Member, I want to urge the Ghana Police Service to ensure that at all material times, the privileges and immunities of Members, especially when the House is in Session, are adhered to. It is for a good reason that even if you are in the position to deal with a law enforcement officer, you cannot do that because that law enforcement officer represents the law and the country. And if you attempt to resist or even to lay hands on that officer, you are dealt with ruthlessly. They have privileges and immunities; it is for Members of Parliament too. But this is not to shield any Member from the full impact of the rule of law.

I want it to be made clear once more that these privileges are not absolute. They must be exercised responsibly and in accordance with the laws of the land. I assure all Ghanaians, in particular, the

security agencies, of the full cooperation of Parliament in this investigation and all other pending investigations involving Members of Parliament.

With this, I thank you for your attention.

Since it touches on Members of Parliament and the Leaders of the Members are here, if they have anything to say, they should say it now, starting with the Minority Leader.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, let me thank you for the space to add a few words to what you have just said. Indeed, democracy provides that the actors must have an opportunity to politic; do politics, share ideas and have their views, disagree and agree. It is however, part of democracy also for the core issues of national discourse to be agreed upon by the active stakeholders in this process.

Mr Speaker, the matter you have just raised, *galamsey*, is one thing that for the want of a better word, I must say, that we as political leaders, active stakeholders of this democracy have failed. And I say so without mincing words. We must, as political actors, know that there are matters that we have to agree upon and nip in the bud.

My recent recollection of this matter dates back to 2015 as a young Member of the Finance Committee. Mr Seth Terkper, Minister for Finance, as he then was, appeared before us and lamented how *galamsey* was affecting cocoa

production. But did the nation listen to him? The former president, Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, put his presidency on the line — *[Interruption]*. Do not go there! Hon Members may have to listen; this is an important matter. This is how committed the President was on this matter. But again, we, as the actors, were looking at the political convenience and the gains. That is why we are where we are.

I was once upon a time the chairman for Ghana Water Company Limited. I saw data for myself of how the country was losing money heavily to treat water because of *galamsey*. It is getting worse. The Civil Society Organisation (CSO) is talking, Organised Labour is talking, religious leaders are talking, but they know that in us, is a vested authority, the people's representatives.

Mr Speaker, can we, as political leaders, for once agree to stay the partisan approach on this matter and deal with it and let our citizens know that this is a matter that affects the country and our own livelihoods? Perhaps, the medical practitioners are not sharing with us the revealing reports in the various hospitals enough. So, it is like business as usual.

Mr Speaker, I would wait for another day where we would discuss this matter in detail. But I would, by way of conclusion, say that the issue of *galamsey* calls for action, collectively. Not a National Democratic Congress (NDC) or New Patriotic Party (NPP) affair, but a Ghana affair so that it does not become like we go to the area the

people are mining and then we say because we may lose election, we do not want to talk about it, or they will even push us to be lawless all in the interest of votes. That would end people up in a coffin. Do we want to be burying people every weekend?

Mr Speaker, let me leave the rest for the Leader of the House to put out for the records and pray that the time will come for us to have a full discussion on this matter and send a strong message to the nation that enough is enough with the partisan approach on this *galamsey* matter.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the treasured space.

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Thank you very much, Rt Hon Speaker.

I listened to you carefully and I thought what I heard was a formal communication on the question of the privileges of Members of Parliament. I am hoping that our brief comments would focus on the question of privileges. I think what I heard you say is that you will not shield any Member of this House when they are alleged to have committed offences and the law enforcement agencies are seeking to investigate and establish whether indeed, a crime has been committed for the purposes of being prosecuted or held accountable in any other form, shape or manner.

Mr Speaker, you zeroed in on the specific instance of the alleged attack on

the anti- *galamsey* task force. We all heard in the media that there was an attack on an anti- *galamsey* task force in Asutifi South, and I later got some indication that a Member on this Side of the House is alleged to have instigated some community members to resist the work of the task force.

3:15 p.m.

Mr Speaker, let me indicate that yesterday,

I got a call from the Minister for the Interior, Hon Muntaka, that the Inspector General of Police (IGP) needed the Hon Member for interrogation. I invited the Member, he came to my office, and I was trying to reach Hon Muntaka but I could not. So, ultimately, I had to ask the Member to go. I told him that I will call him back if I reach Hon Muntaka.

Subsequently, Hon Muntaka called me back. He was in a meeting when I was called him. I told him that I had invited the MP and he was ready to come and see whoever he should see, but because we did not hear from him, I had dismissed him. So, we scheduled that the Member be sent to the Criminal Investigations Department (CID) Headquarters this morning to meet with one of the Deputy CID Directors for processing. This morning, he went with our Majority Chief Whip and his lawyer; they received him at the CID headquarters, took him through the processes, and I received a call not quite long ago that he has been taken to court. As we speak, he is actually in court, being arraigned, and so let me also indicate that as Members

of Parliament, we do not consider ourselves being above the law. We are always ready to be held accountable for our actions and inactions.

We passed the law establishing the law enforcement agencies. We approve the appropriations to finance them to carry out these assignments that we have assigned them, and we pass the laws defining the crimes, and we also invite them to this House, and often try to hold them accountable for the extent to which they are enforcing the law. So, we as Members of Parliament will not in any way, I believe, go out of our way deliberately to hamper the law enforcement agencies in the discharge of their duties. I believe, I speak for all my Colleagues, that at any time when any of us is alleged to have committed an offence, we will own up and be ready to defend ourselves and establish our innocence. So, Mr Speaker, just to assure you that MPs will do well to conduct themselves and we will not be calling on you to shield us in any way.

Lastly, Mr Speaker, what I know is that the Hon Member has flatly denied the allegations made about him instigating some community members against the law enforcement agencies, the Military and the Police. I also got a call from the senior Member that you alluded to, Hon Collins Dauda. He called me from South Africa because it happened in his constituency, and he was very surprised about the report that the media has put out there about what really happened. He was also of the firm belief that the report that he received is consistent with the claims being made by

the Hon Member of Parliament that he never instigated members of the communities against the law enforcement agencies.

Be that as it may, he has handed himself over to the Police; has been taken to court, and we are ready to go through all the legal processes. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Hon Members, what I did was a formal communication. It was a formal communication by me on a reported attack on a team of National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS). It is not a formal communication on privileges and immunities. It was just in passing that I mentioned privileges and immunities. But as I said, those are not absolute.

Hon Members, they are being investigated. They have not been convicted. And so, we just want to erase the impression or perception that Hon Members are always being shielded from the due process of the law. You all know that we have never done that. It is just that because you hold some positions, just like the Police, that is why I referred to the Police too. That is why we refer to even the Judiciary. They all enjoy some of these protections by the law. So, the fact that you enjoy protection does not mean you are above the law. That is just what I want to expatiate on and clarify so that we do not all go under that cloud that the Speaker is always protecting Hon Members of Parliament from the due process of the law. I want to thank leaders for their comments and then we proceed to the item numbered 6.

But before we do that, let me acknowledge the presence of our visitors. We have visitors from three institutions. The first is from Abura-Asebu Kwamankese. They are 60 in number and they come from the Abakrampa Senior High Technical School. They are led by the Assistant Head of Academics, Mr Michael Kwadwo Eduah. Hon Members, you can see them at the Public Gallery on the left side of the Speaker. On your behalf, I want to warmly welcome them to the House and to thank them for taking their time to come and see what we do here. I believe they will also learn a bit from the visit, in spite of their very tender ages. This is one of the processes we set in place. It is in motion to capture them young, so that in future, as I keep on saying, they will perform better than us. So, you are most welcome. You may now resume your seats.

[Students from Abakrampa Senior High Technical were acknowledged].

The Speaker: The second group is from the Heritage Christian University. They are from Amasaman and are 13 in number. They are led by the Speaker of the SRC Group. I told you I have colleagues all over the country. So today, one is here. He is the Speaker of the SRC Group and so you see the fire is catching on. So many areas are forming Parliaments and having Speakers and it is something that you should all encourage and support. The leader is Mr Hope Huzey and they are also at the left side of the Speaker. You are most welcome. This is your House and any time you get the opportunity, you can

even come as an individual, not as a group. So that together, we share the commitment to make sure that democracy is entrenched in our system of governance. You are most welcome. You may resume your seats.

[Students from Heritage Christian University were acknowledged.]

3:25 p.m.

The Speaker: The third group is from the Ghana National Association of Teachers, those who made it possible for us to be here. That is the father of all professions and I know you treasure them very much. They are 47 in number and from the Kwabre East Constituency.

The leader of the group is Mr Richard Ampedu. Sir and Madam, you are warmly welcome. I treasure my teachers so much because they made it possible for me to be the Speaker. So, we are extremely grateful for what you are doing in spite of our failure to be able to remunerate you well. Do not worry, it is not in heaven that you would receive your reward; you will receive it here if democracy works well. We are happy you are to learn to assist us to make sure that democracy actually works and produces the dividends that can be equitably shared to all.

So, you are welcome. Please resume your seats and monitor what is going to happen next.

[Members of the Ghana National Association of Teachers (GNAT), Kwabre East, were acknowledged.]

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT

The Speaker: Hon Members, the next item is Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

We will start with the correction of the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 31st October, 2025.

Page 1...6—

Yes, Hon Member for Zabzugu, is your issue on page 6?

Mr Alhassan Umar: Mr Speaker, thank you.

My name has been captured as absent on page 7, item numbered 70 but I submitted a request for leave of absence, so it should be captured under absent with permission.

The Speaker: Hon Member, it does not necessarily mean that when you submit your leave of absence, you have been granted permission. It does not mean that at all. Kindly follow up to see whether permission has been granted. When it is granted, draw the attention of the Table Office so that they can correct this. If it is not granted, it means you are absent.

Hon Members, do not just file your request for leave of absence and take it for granted that the permission has been granted by the Speaker.

Yes, Hon Member for Kwahu Afram Plains?

Mr Worlase Kpeli: Mr Speaker, on the same page, I have been captured as absent without permission, but I was absent on a Committee assignment.

The Speaker: The page you are referring to talks about Members who are absent. They did not add “without permission.” So, you have to follow the same procedure. Cross check to see whether you were granted permission. If not, then it is correct. If you were granted permission, then draw the attention of the Table Office to the error.

Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I seek further guide on what you have said. The procedure now is that, at least what we have inherited, is that Members who file their leave of absence form with the Whips, and then when we endorse it, we ferry it to the office of the Clerk to Parliament. In fact, now the arrangement is that we do so electronically, and it is then transmitted to your Office for your action. So, it is the delay because sometimes, the request comes in respect of a trip that lasts for, say, two days. I have all the evidence of my electronic transmission to the office of the Clerk to Parliament, and then it is further ferried to your Office for action.

But we are correcting the *Votes and Proceedings*, and once we correct and adopt it, then it is gone. Members have come to see me regarding this matter just today, so my intention was to engage the Clerk to Parliament after today's proceeding and see how we can

streamline things. If the procedure can be shortened, then we can refer it directly to your Office for action, or if somebody can be designated to do that.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon First Deputy Minority Whip?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I do not know if that is the new procedure, because if one picks up the form, it is for the Caucus Leadership to recommend, and then the next portion is for the Speaker to endorse. There is no column for the Clerk to Parliament. Can we get further clarification from it, because my understanding and the practice have always been the case that if Leadership endorse, it goes to the Speaker. The Speaker elects based on communication to us that either of the Deputy Speakers is working on it. So, I do not know, if maybe our—Because when we endorse, we know it goes to either of the Speakers. On the form, it says “the Speaker”. I do not think the Clerk to Parliament has a role to play in it based on what has been provided on the form.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I was very clear in what I said. It is about the procedure of submission to the Office of the Speaker. I am saying the procedure I inherited, and what I agreed with the Clerk to Parliament was that when we recommend for approval, it is ferried to the office of the Clerk to Parliament for onwards transmission for Speaker's approval or otherwise. We do not send it directly to the Office of the Speaker. So, this can be streamlined. I do not think we should litigate this, but I did indicate that the Clerk to Parliament has a role to play

by signing a portion. I am only talking about the procedure of submission.

The Speaker: Hon Members, you do not need to split hairs over this. How many of you seated here have your copies of the Standing Orders?

[Hon Members raised their copies of the Standing Orders.]

3:35 p.m.

The Speaker: Yes, I can see.

Yes, raise your Standing Orders; it could be on your phone or whatever.

Could you all read Order 15? Then you can judge for yourselves which of your Leaders is right. I think on a daily basis, I have to be conducting examinations on the Standing Orders.

For the sake of the public, I am going to read it because it is a thorny issue.

“Order 15 — Leave of absence

- (1) A Member shall attend sittings of the House unless the Speaker grants leave of absence to the Member in writing.
- (2) A Member seeking to be absent shall complete a Leave of Absence Form as specified in the Second Schedule.
- (3) The Leave of Absence Form may be obtained from the Office of the Clerk, the Table Office or

the Office of the Chief Whip of the Caucus of the Member.

- (4) A Member shall submit the completed Leave of Absence Form to the Chief Whip of the Caucus of the Member not later than seventy-two hours prior to the intended date of absence.”

How many days is it? Three days.

- “(5) The Chief Whip of the caucus of that Member shall, not later than twenty-four hours after receipt, transmit the completed Leave of Absence form with recommendation to the Speaker for consideration.

- (6) The Speaker may, within twenty-four hours of receipt, grant leave of absence to a Member who shows sufficient cause.”

It is not automatic, so if you submit a leave of absence form to me and state that you are visiting your girlfriend—*[Laughter]*—do you want me to grant that leave of absence?

- “(7) The Office of the Speaker shall, within twenty-four hours after the decision of the Speaker, transmit the decision to the Member through the Office of the Clerk.

- (8) The decision of the Speaker shall be recorded in the Votes and Proceedings.”

This is the procedure. So, if the Clerk's Office does not receive a written permission from the Speaker, they cannot submit it to the Table Office for it to be captured. We have given timelines for all this to be done. In fact, I am surprised by the mention of the electronic copies that are transmitted to the Clerk, who is to forward them to the Speaker.

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, that is the procedure.

The Speaker: Which rule says so? You are a lawyer.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, Mr Speaker. Order 15, from rule one up to the eighth that you just read. Now, the issue is with when we are done as Whips—Because practically, it is not every time that Mr Speaker, you are *in situ*, and yet the approval must come. I recall vividly my discussion with the Clerk – once the approval comes, we transmit.

He made a point that sometimes, he is able to communicate with you electronically. So even though you are not here, it can be done; approval can be given. And it is more expeditious than me carrying a file of 15 leave of absence recommended forms, coming to your Secretariat, when you are unavoidably not around, and leaving it. Meanwhile, the 72 hours is ticking. So these are administratively enhanced means of getting the approvals readily done.

Mr Speaker, I do not think that it departs from what the procedure

provides at all. It is about the means of ferrying the recommended leave of absence applications to you expressly.

The Speaker: Your focus is on the mode of transmission, which is electronic, but I am talking about the person. Well, your earlier submission was that you forward them to the Clerk, who then sends them to the Speaker. And I am saying it is not so by the rule. In fact, that was what Hon Habib also stated. That it is direct from you, the Chief Whip, to the Speaker, not to the Clerk.

It is when the Speaker grants permission that the Speaker then sends it to the Clerk because the Table Office is under the Clerk. That is part of the office of the Clerk. And this after the Speaker has agreed that you have shown sufficient cause to be granted the permission. That is why I cited that if you write to me for permission to visit your girlfriend, do you think I should? Even if she is sick, I will not grant you that permission.

Please, just follow the procedure because we have put structures in place; I do not need to be present. And I have communicated to you, Leaders, as to who I have put in charge of that process. May we move on now?

Page 8—

Yes?

Mr Albert Tetteh Nyakotey: May I take you back to page 7? On page 7, the item numbered 50, I was marked absent, but I was on Committee duty outside the office.

The Speaker: So, follow the same guidance I gave to the earlier one. Follow up and see whether you were granted permission to absent yourself. If you were granted, then you draw the attention of the Table Office to rectify the error.

Mr Nyakotey: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

3: 45 p.m.

The Speaker: Page 8...12?

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of the Eighth Sitting, dated Friday, 31st October, 2025, as presented and corrected is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

I do not have any copy of the *Official Report*, so we will proceed to the next item on the *Order Paper* that is the item numbered 7, Questions.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I would want to bring an important matter to your attention and to that of Hon Leader of Government Business. Mr Speaker, we have Questions piled-up, and unfortunately for us, we are getting a lot of letters from Ministers, to state they would not be available. I would want to use the opportunity to plead with the Leader of Government Business to see to this matter. Members have their Questions and some are time-bound, and the Ministers are not available. It is all

about “I am not available”— Some of these letters come at the last minute, and they get communicated to Leadership. It makes life quite difficult. The Ministers owe a responsibility to this House.

Mr Speaker, I will not belabour the point.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we discussed the issue of scheduling Ministers at the Business Committee on Thursday, and we agreed that we should always try to ensure Ministers are aware before we schedule them. If they are not available, they can indicate a convenient date. I have not received letters. In fact, I have just received a communication from the Minister for Roads and Highways who we all know is very punctual and comes to answer all Questions. For instance, tomorrow, he has some Questions but he has to be in Sawla-Tuna-Kalba area for inauguration, so he will not be able to make it. He wants his Questions rescheduled to Thursday. Those types of indications come. The Hon Minister who is scheduled to answer Questions today was supposed to come last week, but then she requested that we schedule her today. Today she is here to answer all the Questions.

Mr Speaker, I think that we have been doing well with the scheduling of Questions. All Questions are being asked. Indeed, last week, there was even a Question asking the Minister how many shrines we have in Ghana. There

was a Question about the number of shrines we have in Ghana. The Hon Minority Leader was not here. His Side had the opportunity to ask all sorts of Questions including how many shrines are in Ghana. And the Minister was here to answer to the Question of how many shrines are in Ghana. So, I can assure you that the Ministers are always available to answer Questions. If for some reason they cannot make it, they have to write, and when they notify us, we reschedule them. I do not think there is a problem with Ministers showing up to answer Questions. It is normal Business. If you are not available, you need to write and they write.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, ordinarily, I would not have come in because the two Leaders have related to the subject matter. Just to put a bit of a twist to it, for want of a better expression. I have sat in the Business Committee meeting and this matter has come back and forth. The Hon Majority leader will concede that the crux of the Hon Minority Leader's concern is a trend that is increasingly emerging. This House has the powers to determine when Ministers should be in this House to respond to Questions, and not the reverse. The trend emerging is that the Questions go through the process, I must commend the Table for doing a wonderful job, and all we hear is that, "I am not available". You can write to communicate to this House that you are not available, but it will take this House to tell you whether your reasoning will be acceptable to this House or not.

Mr Speaker, what is happening? He mentioned the Minister for Roads and Highways. As for the Minister for Roads and Highways, if there is any Minister who is always in the Chamber, with the greatest respect to my Colleagues who are Ministers, the Minister for Roads and Highways is always here. We are not overly simplifying this matter and revolving it around the Minister for Roads and Highways.

The Hon Majority Leader should look into my eyes and listen to me; the Hon Majority Leader should listen to me today. When the Hon Majority Leader talks about a Member asking Questions about the number of shrines, does the Hon Member know what we are seeking to do? That is very typical of him. He will try to trivialise the matter and then off we go. No. Mr Speaker, the time for the Ministers to respond to Questions has to be determined by this House.

Why? Do they want to take over our oversight powers?

3:51 p.m. — [HON SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR ANDREW ASIAMA AMOAKO, IN THE CHAIR]

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: So, this matter, we will have to exhaust it. I am simply saying that we must set the date and that has been the practice of this House. Where the Ministers cannot attend upon the House, they must write. That is the basic process and practice. The Ministers must write to us, and the House will determine whether to accept or not. Where the Minister cannot come, his or

her deputy should be able to come to this House. We have a number of Questions that are piling up and we are not getting Answers. It is worrying. Hon Majority Leader, maybe we may have to reflect on this matter more at the Business Committee and develop a way out. We cannot leave these Questions hanging. No, it cannot be — *[Interruption]*

Ms Helen Adjoa Ntoso: The Hon Minister is in the House to answer Questions so allow her.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: It is a matter we have to talk about. We will allow our Colleague, our respected Minister—

Mr Speaker, I am inviting you to direct— The powers of the Business Committee are defined. The Business Committee cannot take a decision for Plenary. No, we cannot. You can only come with a proposed programme subject to an endorsement by Plenary. So, Hon Majority Leader, with respect to you, when you say that the Business Committee— You are a respected lawyer, we respect you. You are going beyond your powers. The Business Committee will have to look at this matter again. We on this side of the House, insist. Not too long ago, you were here. You were asking all the Questions. Why are you shielding the Ministers? I want to look into the eyes of the Hon Majority Leader. Mr Majority Leader, why are you shielding your Ministers? They said they have achieved so much within one year. They should come and answer Questions and they are writing all manner of excuses. Within a week, we have received so much of excuses. Why?

Maybe the President should be looking at the first reshuffle. The Ministers must come and attend upon this House and respond to Questions coming from the people's representatives. We in this House cannot take it lightly. So, Hon Majority Leader— now you are looking into my eyes. We will be expecting the Ministers to respond, and they must respond.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, I think the Hon Minister is here.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister is here, yes, but the Majority Leader must tell us something.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You should know your Friend, Kwame Agbodza is also sitting here.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: No, Mr Speaker. I am not talking about the Minister for Roads and Highways. The Hon Minister for Roads and Highways is an exception. He knows. In terms of his presence in this House, even though my road is not done, that is fine— *[Laughter]*—The Minister of Roads and Highways is always here. So, Hon Majority Leader, I beg you. We may have to look at this matter again at the Business Committee and maybe structure a roadmap.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leader?

3.55 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, in all this, he has not displayed to this House one

single letter asking for extension of time by any Minister, and yet he has said more than a hundred times since he was on his feet that Ministers write letters asking for postponement. He has not shown a single letter from a Minister asking for postponement. Show us the evidence.

The reputation of a whole group, that is the Ministers, who are part of the highest placed appointments in the country is at stake here. When he stands here and says that when Ministers are asked Questions, they write letters seeking postponement *et cetera* stating that they are unavailable, and he does not display a single letter, it is not good and fair to them. So please, he should show me the letters. There are no letters. I am not saying that they ask trivial questions. [An Hon Member: You said “all sorts of Questions”] No, I did not say that. I said that you are free to ask all sorts of Questions.

They even asked a Question about the number of shrines in Ghana. I said that last week, they wanted the Hon Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to tell us how many shrines we have in Ghana. The Hon Minister came here and gave an indication that he did not know the number of shrines we have in Ghana. I am giving an indication of the type of Questions we ask and how those Questions are transmitted to the Hon Ministers for them to come and answer those Questions. I am not trivialising their Questions. So please, Hon Ministers do show up to answer Questions. Where they are unavailable, they indicate that, because they also have

responsibilities and I just gave the House an example.

The Hon Minister for Roads and Highways is sitting here but he is scheduled to answer Questions tomorrow, then he has to perform a sod cutting ceremony in the Savannah Region. So, he was just asking me if I could reschedule his Questions to Thursday, and I agreed with him. I said he should write to the House and he has written.

But when there is good cause, the Rules are clear—Let me just read the Rules again:

“Order 77 (1), (2) and (3):

(1) A Minister, a Member or the Head of an Independent Constitutional Body shall, by order of the House, attend a sitting of the House to answer a Question.

(2) Question time shall ordinarily not exceed one hour except that the Speaker may permit a Question after the expiration of the time stated.

Order 77 (3) is where I really want to focus on.

(3) A Minister, a Member or the Head of an Independent Constitutional Body shall not take more than three weeks, upon receipt of a Question from the House to respond to the Question.”

So, Ministers have three weeks upon receipt of the Question to answer them. If we would recall, at the last Business Committee meeting, the Hon Minority Chief Whip was not there, I raised the issue of whether or not the Table Office should deal directly with the Hon Ministers or with their staff. They confirmed that they have schedule officers at the Ministries that they deal with. I asked how sure are they that when we deal with a schedule officer, the Hon Ministers have actual notice of the Question and the time scheduled for the Ministers to come and answer the Question? They admitted that there was no guarantee that when they deal with a schedule officer, the Hon Minister has notice. At that meeting, I said that let us make it a practise as a Business Committee to always call the Hon Ministers and let them know that we have scheduled them on certain days so that they are aware of it. There and then, we started calling the Hon Ministers. The Ministers did confirm that they did not know about the schedule of those Questions. For some of them, the dates that we scheduled were not convenient. So, we directly engaged them and rescheduled it to dates that were convenient, including the Hon Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture, who is here today. They can ask her; she is here. We called her and she said she was not available the day that we scheduled her. We asked when she would be available and she gave us today. That is how come all her Questions have been scheduled, and she is here.

So, the issue has always been the way that we do Business. Because the Rule

says the Hon Ministers should be the ones that should have notice of the Questions. They are the ones that must come, and they have three weeks to come. But when we run our practises in a way that the person that should have notice does not have, we cannot blame that person for not coming. That is the issue that the Rt Hon Speaker just addressed, where even with a leave of absence, the communication does not get to the person who is supposed to grant the leave. So, let us also iron out our practises and our procedures so that we can comply strictly with our Rules.

We cannot say that the Hon Ministers are not coming to answer Questions and that they are always asking for change of dates. Because the Rule is that we engage them and agree with them when they can come, but then they have three weeks within which they must come. Those are the issues.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister is here. The Rule is clear that we should not exceed one hour of Question time, except with your discretion or leave. So, let us have the Hon Minister answer the Questions. The Hon Minority Chief Whip and I should take this matter up at the Business Committee meeting and resolve them. It is in the province of the Business Committee.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, this is not to belabour the point but just to establish one fact. I see my Colleague, the respected Hon Samuel Jinapor wants to speak. The point must be made that we

on this Side appreciate the fact that we can agree to disagree, and we should get practical. There are times that the Hon Majority Leader engages us and says that—I recall not too long ago we had to reduce the number of follow-ups as a result of our engagement at the Business Committee. It was because of the exigencies of the Business that we had at that time.

Our problem is that, it is against our practise for the Table Office to be told that they must seek the availability of the Ministers before they schedule the Questions; that is wrong. Parliament must schedule the Questions and the Ministers must respond. He was citing the example of the Minister for Roads and Highways. There are times where we have even rescheduled at Conclave without necessarily receiving a formal correspondent from the Ministers.

So, the Hon Majority Leader must get the point that we are with him. We want Businesses to be done and we want to get critical. But Parliament cannot be at the discretion of the Executive; no, that cannot be. We must schedule the Hon Ministers and our scheduling is not based on the availability of the Ministers. No, the Hon Leader should listen to me. When we make the schedule and the Hon Ministers are not available, it is their duty to write to Parliament, otherwise, our oversight role will be undermined. So, I am saying that, to say that we should seek the availability of the Ministers before we schedule them is wrong and against our practise. The Business Committee cannot make that determination for Plenary. That is where

I want to revert the mind of the Hon Majority Leader to so that we can make progress. Where the Ministers are engaged and they cannot come, sometimes they do not even write, they call us the Leaders and we have often acceded to it. So, the Hon Majority Leader, should not get it wrong. We are not saying that even where the Hon Ministers cannot come, we are insisting that the Ministers should be here.

No, where there are genuine reasons, we are reasonable to know that we have to accede to those reasonable grounds being given. But when it becomes like Parliament must call the Ministers and the Ministers must accede before this scheduling is done, that for me is against the practise and will be undermining our oversight as an arm of government. That is my simple view.

4:05 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the point being made is not that the Hon Ministers should dictate the time.

At that Business Committee meeting, there was a complaint about Ministers not showing up to answer Questions. Then I asked if they knew they had been scheduled to answer Questions; that was the question I asked. I asked how they communicate to the Ministers when they have Questions to answer. She then revealed that there is a contact person at the ministry that they deal with. Then I asked if she was sure the contact people communicate this to the Ministers, because it might just be that the Ministers are not even aware. Because sometimes I

come and sit here, then I notice that the Minister has Questions he is not aware of. So, I call him and tell him, that Minister, you have Questions to answer.

The problem that I face then is that he is not aware of the Question. He is actually ready to come, but then he is not prepared to answer the Question. He is not prepared and has not been properly briefed. When Ministers come without being properly briefed, it becomes embarrassing for me when they appear not to be on top of their brief. So, I prefer that the Ministers are made aware, prepared, and are on top of their brief and then they can answer the Question competently to the satisfaction of the Members.

At that meeting, we asked if it is possible for us as a Committee to always call them, to be sure that first, they are aware and secondly, to agree with them on their availability. I am saying that the Rule says that he must show up within three weeks upon receipt of the Question. It means that he has three weeks' latitude to negotiate with Members. If he receives it today and they call him and say, they would schedule them tomorrow morning, they can say, "no and that they would come in two weeks' time or even a day before the expiry of the three weeks." He has that latitude. So, when he gives that indication, he is not saying that the Legislature is being subjugated to the whims and caprices of the Executive.

The Rules gave him three weeks; our rules say in three weeks. So, it gives him ample room to fix the time when he will come and answer the Questions within

the three weeks. So, I do not see where we are going with this.

Let me just plead with the Speaker that we have the Minister answer the Questions. Because if we also summon Ministers to come and answer Questions and they come and sit here and then we engage in long, winding arguments and debates about the Questions that they are here to answer—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: It is very important. When he says that Ministers come here and we elect to engage in long discussions, that is most unfortunate to come from the Majority Leader. This is the Parliament of Ghana and we determine our Business. We are not part of the Executive. This is an arm of government—I am talking to Ministers—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker But incidentally, he is also a Member of Parliament.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, that comment is most unfortunate. To say that we engage in long, winding statements. Oh! Majority Leader—You made a fantastic point. That one is unfortunate, withdraw that part. This is Parliament and everything we speak to here, makes sense and is important. The long, winding debates are important. But the Ministers must contain us—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, you know about 80 per cent of the Ministers are already

Members of Parliament. So, once they come here, they have come to their home to do business. Being a Minister is just an additional responsibility. So just saying that “we allow them to sit there”, I do not think that is right. Because they have come to their House to do Business. Irrespective of the fact that they are ministers, they have come as Members of Parliament. So, their time is not being wasted when they come here.

I do not think that I am with you on that score.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, there can be long, winding arguments that are very intelligent and sensible. There are very intelligent, sensible, long, winding arguments that educate, engage and excite Members of this House.

Mr Speaker, I am not even saying that the arguments are not sensible; they are very sensible. Yes, they can be long and it is good. I am just encouraging us that when we summon the Ministers and they come—of course, they are Members of Parliament and should ordinarily be here as Members of Parliament. But do not forget that our Constitution has partially merged the Executive with the Legislature. So, we have members of the Executive who have executive functions at the same time legislative functions.

Mr Speaker, we know the cost of running Government and we know that it has been very costly. So, when we reduce the size of the number of Ministers, we must also accompany that with greater efficiency in the use of Ministers' time. That is all that I am pleading for. When

they come, let us have them answer their Questions, so that they can get back to work at the ministries.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right, Minister, I would call you back. I think Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor has indicated to speak. Hon, be snappy before I get back to the Minister.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor: Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to this very important discussion.

Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader talked about all sorts of Questions and referred to a Question which sought to ask the Minister the number of shrines in Ghana. May I refer the House to Order 85(1), I read:

“The Speaker is responsible for the admissibility of a Question.”

Therefore, any Question which is scheduled and asked in this House must pass the admissibility test and it is the Speaker who determines which Question is admissible or not. Mr Speaker, I want to believe that you have a criterion and a very high standard in determining whether a Question is admissible or not.

Mr Speaker, with the greatest respect to the Majority Leader, they cannot be “all sorts of Questions.” The Questions that are admitted by the Rt Hon Speaker are Questions that the Speaker, pursuant to Order 85(1), has determined are Questions which are relevant, which Ministers must spend their executive

time to answer and further the interests of our country.

Mr Speaker, to suggest that a particular Question is a sort of Question and that if somebody wanted to know the number of shrines in Ghana, somehow or other, is a sort of Question or a trivial question—

Mr Speaker, finally, when you look at Order 77, it sets out clearly the procedure to be adhered to for Ministers to answer Questions. Standing Order 77 (1), (2) and (3), sets out copiously the procedure to be followed. In all humility and modesty, when we were on their right-hand side and had the privilege to serve in Government—I have spent four or five hours in this House before to answer Questions. My Brother, Mr Asenso Boakye, tells me that he has also sometimes spent six hours or seven hours to answer Questions. If we ever—
[Interruption]

Mr Akandoh: Seven hours? Ei!

Mr S. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, you get here and you are scheduled for 10 o'clock, and sometimes you are admitted around 2 to 4 o'clock. You spend three or four hours to answer.

But what is the point? The fundamental point I seek to make—When we missed Questions, there was a whole brouhaha. The fundamental point is this, answering Questions before the House—The principle behind it is accountability and that is the point the Minority Chief Whip is making. It is the

extent to which we take the Business of the House seriously.

Mr Speaker, I think that the Majority Leader is right in saying that we should allow the Minister for Fisheries to answer her Questions. But the fundamental point is that admissibility is by the Speaker and answering Questions goes to the root of accountability.

Finally, the winding arguments, the Majority Leader has most of it. He takes a bigger bite of the winding argument.

Thank you Mr Speaker.

4:15 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Kojo?

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, thank you.

On a point of elucidation, Order 77 (1), and I think we need to pay attention to the language that the Standing Order uses. It states:

“A Minister, a Member or the Head of an Independent Constitutional Body shall, by order of the House, attend a sitting of the House to answer a Question.”

The spirit of this Standing Order is not to suggest that it is a negotiation; it is a request. It is not a plea or a favour that a Minister is doing this House to attend upon it to respond to Questions. In fact, properly speaking, it operates as though it summons, except that there is a period

within which notice is given for the Minister to prepare.

So, Mr Speaker, just to say that we should be careful about this interpretation that suggests as though, we have to negotiate with Ministers and as and when they can, they attend upon this House. The proper language is that it is by order.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I think it is almost the same thing. It is by order, but if indeed the time the Question gets to the Minister and they are not available— Obviously, we need to negotiate it.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I do not think there is any disagreement here. By order of the House, a Minister must come here and answer Questions. If it is an Urgent Question, it is treated differently. If it is an Oral Question, it is treated differently. But the same Standing Order says that upon receipt of the notice, he or she has three weeks. So, if I as Leader of Government business, say, let me engage with the Minister within those three weeks to see when the Minister is available to come and answer the Questions—

Mr Speaker, once your own rules say the person has three weeks, the person has discretion within the three weeks. I did not make the rules. The rule says the person has three weeks. It means that if I ask a Minister to come next week, and

the Minister says they want to make it the following week, I will be better prepared because we ask Questions about facts.

For instance, if I ask a Question such as how many shrines are there in Ghana, it takes time to count shrines. *[Laughter]*. First, you have to identify the location of the shrines.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, thank you so much.

Hon Members, let us turn to the item numbered 7 on page 2. We will start the Questions with that of Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta.

Mrs Laurette Korkor Asante: Mr Speaker, I rise on Order 88(3) to seek your permission to ask this Question on behalf of the Hon Member for Fanteakwa South. I have his authorisation to ask this Question.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, leave granted.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF FISHERIES AND AQUACULTURE

Operationalisation of the One-Stop-Shop Aquaculture Licensing System and its Impact on Regulatory Compliance and Investment

Mrs Laurette Korkor Asante on behalf of Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (NPP — Fanteakwa South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture the steps

being taken to operationalise the One-Stop-Shop Aquaculture Licensing System in 2025, and how this reform will improve regulatory compliance and investment in the aquaculture industry.

Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture (Mrs Emelia Arthur): Mr Speaker, the Government of Ghana acknowledges aquaculture's role in food security, employment and economic growth. The current process for obtaining aquaculture licences involves various regulatory bodies, each with its own requirements and procedures, creating a fragmented system. This arrangement has resulted in overlapping regulations, manual processing and delays. Aquaculture operators are required to liaise with multiple agencies, which increases administrative tasks and prolongs the approval process, impacting the sector's efficiency.

The Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture, through the Fisheries Commission, is introducing a One-Stop-Shop Aquaculture Licensing System designed to simplify and coordinate the permitting process in Ghana. The goal is to establish a unified digital platform that consolidates approvals from key regulatory agencies, aiming to improve efficiency, transparency and delivery service within the sector.

Preparatory measures undertaken include the development of Guidelines for the Aquaculture Permitting System, providing information on licensing procedures and requirements. Additionally, a draft Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) has been prepared

involving the Fisheries Commission, Environmental Protection Authority (EPA), and Water Resources Commission (WRC) to support collaboration in developing and implementing the system. Software development for the One-Stop-Shop platform is complete and being tested currently for full rollout planned for 2026. The Fisheries staff are being trained on the software management and whole process for complete takeover and implementation. This reform is intended to enhance regulatory compliance, facilitate investment in the aquaculture industry, and reduce in-person interactions by introducing a more transparent and trackable approval process.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any further Question?

Yes, Hon Member for Bosome Freho Constituency.

Mr Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I first and foremost want to commend the Government and the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture for continuing a process that has been in the system since 2022.

Mr Speaker, the National Fisheries and Aquaculture Policy that was enacted in 2020, and the Ghana National Aquaculture Development Plan between 2024 and 2028 was working on this one-stop-shop licensing. I want to ask that the new plan or development that they are doing, has it abandoned all these

provisions and regulations or things that were being done by the 2022 policy or the plan for 2024-2028 entirely, or some of those plans have been inculcated into the new one that has been completed?

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mrs Arthur: Thank you very much.

The process that we inherited was reviewed and improved, and that is what we are rolling out now.

4:25 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. No, I would not give the Hon Member two opportunities.

Yes, Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister tells us that this one-stop-shop aquaculture licencing system in 2025 has seen some Ministerial intervention. May I know from her what exactly she means by one-stop-shop aquaculture licencing system?

Mrs Arthur: Thank you very much. By statute, it is the Fisheries Commission and the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture that supervise aquaculture. However, to get a licence, there are a number of different entities in Ghana that have to do their part. So, one has to get some licence from Environmental Protection Authority (EPA), have a licence from Fisheries

Commission itself and have the Water Resources Commission also do their bit. What is happening is that increasingly, people who are interested in investing in aquaculture have to go between and among all these agencies running around. In fact, one of the farmers said to us that he pays less to the Fisheries Commission that provides more help to his enterprise than to EPA and to Water Resources Commission. So, the one-stop-shop licencing regime is developing a platform that brings all these licencing processes at one place. So, one can even sit in their bedroom and put in their requirements as each entity requests of them, the process is done, and the person gets their licence.

We are doing this together: EPA, Water Resources Commission, and Fisheries Commission have been working closely together in developing the one-stop-shop licencing permits regime. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Minister.

Yes, Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the Hon Minister's explanation takes me to the point she herself raised in respect of the platform that would be used to achieve this. She tells us that there is a software that has been developed to achieve this. May I know from her, the costs involved in this? As she may be well aware, the programme started somewhere in 2022, and some costing was done. Is she able to tell us whether the previous cost is

being maintained, or that the Ministry has arrived at a new cost for this particular procurement?

Mrs Arthur: Indeed, there was very little progress done from the reference point of 2022. We have had to sort of revamp the whole process, but as I stand here right now, I do not have the actual figures. If Parliament permits, I will provide it later.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I think it is only fair to oblige the respected Minister to make the costing available at a later date, since she has committed for *Hansard* so I would oblige her. But may I know whether the procurement of this software went through competitive tendering, or it was sole sourcing? And if so, whether Public Procurement Authority (PPA) was at all involved in the processes that arrived at this decision?

Mrs Arthur: Thank you very much. As my Answer stated, this work was done through the Fisheries Commission. I will come back to him with answers to his questions. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: That is in respect of the procurement. Very well.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, Question time is not a platform or a time for debate. But when the Minister herself gives us information, the presumption is that all the facts are at her disposal. If she comes to the House of Parliament to say that the Ministry has undertaken a procurement, and a software developer has been selected for

a particular purpose, a question would necessarily follow. So, if she now says that she does not know, it becomes a problem. I want her to provide clarity on this matter. Is it that she would want to come at a later date with the details of the procurement for this House to peruse, because this is critical, with respect.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, I do not think she said she did not know.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, that is why I am saying, clarity and that is why we are having this engagement, with respect.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker. So let me assure the Hon Member that the proper procurement processes have been followed throughout since I assumed leadership of this Ministry. The Hon Member's specific question was what type of procurement approach was used. Whether by single—There is nothing like sole source, I am told. There is single source or whatever and that is what I am saying that I will provide the information later. But I want to assure the Hon Member that the proper procurement processes were followed to procure the software that is being deployed now. Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, to bring a closure to this, since we always want to encourage our countrymen and women to be players in the private sector, may I know from the Minister, in view of the answer given, whether or not this software which was procured was by an entity within our jurisdiction. Simply put, is the software

provider a Ghanaian? Because, Mr Speaker, sometimes we hear that the opportunity goes out of the country.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Is it a Ghanaian or a Ghanaian company?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: A Ghanaian company, Mr Speaker. I mean, the company persona, so if I say Ghanaian, obviously, but I thank you for the guidance. So, I mean a Ghanaian company. I just want to know.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, it is a Ghanaian entity. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, we turn to Question numbered 347.

Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Minister is saying sole source is different from single source, and now it is a Ghanaian entity. Mr Speaker, we want clarity. Entity, in what context? We just want to know. Is it a Ghanaian entity? Bring clarity in an ordinary and simple language. Is it a Ghanaian registered company? Is that what you mean by entity? I want to know.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister. Is it a Ghanaian company? That is all.

Mrs Arthur: A Ghanaian entity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: That is what he wants.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: What do you mean by a Ghanaian entity?

Mrs Arthur: A Ghanaian entity is a Ghanaian.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Is it a Ghanaian company registered in—

Mrs Arthur: A Ghanaian entity in Ghana. Thank you.

4:35 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Thank you.

Let us turn to Question numbered 347. This stands in the name of the same Hon Member, Hon Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta, Member for Fanteakwa South.

So, Hon Member for Atiwa West, you may ask the Question on behalf of your Colleague.

Establishment of Proposed Blue-Economy Commission

Mrs Laurette Korkor Asante on behalf of Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (NPP — Fanteakwa South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture when the proposed Blue-Economy Commission will be established and what legal or institutional framework will guide its operations.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, there is too much noise in the Chamber, and that is why you did not hear the Question.

Yes, Hon Minister?

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, Ghana's blue economy relies on the interconnectedness of water bodies (oceans and rivers), climate resilience and human wellbeing, supporting sectors such as fisheries, maritime transport, tourism, oil and gas, renewable energy as well as marine biotechnology. These sectors are vital for GDP growth, employment, food security and trade. In line with this, Cabinet approved an interministerial technical team, supervised by the Senior Presidential Advisor on Governmental Affairs, to develop a National Blue Economy Strategy and to recommend the appropriate legal and institutional frameworks. The draft strategy and framework have been completed and are currently under Cabinet review. The Ministry is also awaiting feedback on a request to African Union Interafrican Bureau for Animal resources (AU IBAR) to support the development of the implementation plan for the strategy.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Hon Member for Suame?

Mr John Darko: Yes, thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

I have taken notice of the Question asked and the Answer provided by the Hon Minister. The Question is asking specifically when the proposed Blue Economy Commission will be established, but the Answer did not address that at all. The Answer is talking about completely different things. Even though I believe that she may provide an answer she deemed fit, the Answer must actually address the Question.

Mr Speaker, she may want to have a look at her Answer to the Question again.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, that is your understanding. The Minister has researched and provided the House with the Answer. It might not satisfy you, and that you can say.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, my question to the Hon Minister is when does she intend to establish the proposed blue Economy Commission?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon Minister?

Mrs Arthur: Thank you very much. I apologise for not being so explicit in my response. I thought it was inferred.

I said that the national Blue Economy Strategy is now before Cabinet. So, when Cabinet goes through the process and gives the approval, that is only when we can establish the Commission.

Secondly, we do not know as of now whether the appropriate institutional mechanism for implementing the Ghana National Blue Economy Strategy will be the commission. Work has been done,

and it is before Cabinet. Cabinet will study it; we will discuss it and the agreement will follow, as to whether we set up a Blue Economy Commission or something else, we do not know yet. As soon as Cabinet gives approval, we will know when, and the legal and regulatory framework, if necessary, will accompany the establishment and implementation of the Ghana Blue Economy Strategy.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon Member for Ofoase Ayirebi?

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, thank you.

I am still looking for some clarity from the Hon Minister. By which time does the Ministry expect that these internal consultations will be completed for the strategy document to be approved by Cabinet?

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, when we started the process, we reached out to the African Union Interafrican Bureau for Animal Resources, AU-IBAR. They have written to us that they are interested in coming to support the process. The AU-IBAR has just said that they would work within this last quarter. So, what they are going to do is to come to the country, take what we have developed already and add value to it. They may also review it, especially for me, the institutional arrangements and then Cabinet will take the final decision.

I am certain that by the first quarter of 2026, we will have a clear pathway.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Member for Ofoase Ayirebi, I will not give you a second opportunity. Let me go to Hon Member for Odotobri.

Mr Anthony Mmieh: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

My question is how, in the Hon Minister's opinion, would the Commission contribute to the development of her sector, that is the fisheries and aquaculture sector?

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, Blue Economy is, the new kid on the block. It used to be sustainable development, but it is broader now.

We have different sectors under the Blue Economy: energy, transport, tourism, fisheries and a couple of others. The important thing about looking at the fisheries resources is that from a Blue Economy lens is that it broadens the scope and it makes coordination easy.

In the Blue Economy strategy, we have six themes: blue health, blue finance, blue safety and security and others, especially blue equity. It expands the scope of how we engage actors in the sector. It also supports fish stocks and resource management. Within the Blue Economy scope is also the issue of conservation and marine resources management. So, there are many different ways through which the Blue Economy supports Ghana's fisheries,

especially working together with the different sectors that all come under the Blue Economy, so that struggles over who accesses the resources or who has more control over the ocean resources is dealt with at a table, at one go.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me go to Dr Kabiru Tiah Mahama.

Hon Members, we are working within time.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

My question is a very simple one. I want to find out from the Hon Minister, whether the blue water guards form part of this whole Blue Economy, as explained by the Hon Minister.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, respectfully, I will not admit that question. *[Laughter]*

Let me go to Hon Member for Juaben.

Mr Francis Kwabena Berepong Owusu-Akyaw: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

From the Hon Minister's Answer, she said that Cabinet approved inter-ministerial technical team. I want to know which ministries form part of the inter-ministerial technical team.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon Minister?

4:45 p.m.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, the ministries are the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture, Ministry of Energy, Ministry of Transport, Ministry of Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts, and the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources. So, yes, there is some connection with the blue water guards. And then also the National Development Planning Commission, though it is not a ministry, because of its responsibility of overall planning for Ghana, we included them – and then the important 24-hour Economy Secretariat.

Again, because Blue Economy goes beyond just oceans to cover Water body is about aquatic bodies and in Ghana, one of our largest, most important water bodies is the Volta Lake. So, if the 24-Hour Economy is doing the Volta economic corridor, then it just makes sense that we include them in the blue economy development. The way forward in the blue economy is also aquaculture, which includes the Volta Lake and all of its tributaries.

So yes, we included the 24-Hour secretariat in this exercise for a holistic, forward-thinking national strategy. Thank you. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Minister may be reminded

that not long ago, our respected Colleague, the Hon Member for Ofoase Ayirebi, had drawn the attention of the Government to its inability to announce policy in this Chamber, and yet, Ministers talk about it. Standing at the Dispatch box, the Minister is talking about a 24-Hour Economy, a policy document that is not before us. And she is suggesting to us that this their blue economy is part of the ecosystem of this their so-called 24-Hour Economy.

May I know from the Hon Minister whether the blue economy programme she is talking about found space in their manifesto? Because, for instance, when Akufo-Addo implemented Free SHS, it had already been stated in the New Patriotic Party (NPP) manifesto for the 2016 Election.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, the only reason I, the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture, tend to be the foremost—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am repeating that the noise is too much. Let us listen to the Minister.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, the reason I, the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture, tend to be the one speaking the most about the blue economy, is because in the NDC's 2024 election manifesto, mention was made of establishing the Blue Economy Commission under the fisheries sector.

It was actually when we started the work that we realised that blue economy cannot be under one particular sector. Hence, the request and approval for the

inter-ministerial committee and the inter-sectoral technical team to come together to work.

Mr Speaker, the 24-Hour Economy is not a subset of the blue economy. It is the other way round. *[Hear! Hear!]* As far as I am concerned, there has been a lot of work that has been done on the 24-Hour Economy. It has been launched—*[Interruption]* All right, then, maybe to this House, it is alien. All right, fine. But, so whatever—*[Laughter]* Mr Speaker, apologies for using unparliamentary language.

As far as I am aware, as a Minister of this Republic, the 24-Hour Economy is an integral part of our development agenda. And for what they stand to do, it was important that they were reflected in the blue economy strategy development.

We are not interested in piecemeal approaches. We are thinking through and forward-looking, so that we can develop this country to another level altogether in the short time that Ghanaians have given us. Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister acknowledges the fact that the period given to them to govern is short. Yet, according to her, they are now doing some further consultation. So, as we speak, that blue economy policy, which, according to her, was part of the NDC manifesto, and part of the 24-Hour Economy ecosystem policy, has not been implemented. May I know from her whether or not we should expect something on this blue economy in the 2026 Budget?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, in the first place, I am not the Minister for Finance. In the second place, I have just announced here that there is a process underway. In fact, the question was asked here, and I said that we are hopeful that by the first quarter of next year, the strategy may be ready. When the strategy is ready, it comes with the cost of the implementation, and in fact, as I speak to you right now, I have a Norwegian mission in-country that is seeking a continuation of a partnership we had with them that is ending, and the partnership is called Oceans for Development Cooperation.

They are already eager to support Ghana's blue economy national strategy implementation. So, we will start from there, and then we will put the cost on it for the Government to find the rest of the money. When that will happen, I cannot stand here and say so.

Mr Speaker, I am not sure of the interpretation that the Minority Leader gave to my statement that we have a short time to govern. When we went to the polls in 2024, Ghanaians gave us four years to come and deal with the problems.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Minister. Hon Members, the Minister is careful in choosing her words. Please do not put words in her mouth. Yes, Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader is anxious to re-examine the Minister; he should be patient. The Hon Minister is using the despatch box to do politics. Is that what she wants to do? Because she saw the Majority Leader, she now has the energy to do politics.

Mr Speaker, the Minister talks about a pact we have with respect to the Norwegian mission and some work we have been doing as part of this whole ecosystem. She may be aware that the Norwegian Parliament has actually ratified the double taxation agreement. It is all part of this, and we have not.

As part of the strategies for full implementation, can she assure this House that she will take steps to ensure that the agreement is ratified by this Parliament so that our people can also benefit in terms of this policy that is being rolled out?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

4:55 p.m.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, this double taxation arrangement does not fall under my Ministry.

It falls under the Ministry of Finance. I cannot stand here in the despatch box and commit the Minister for Finance.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I will not belabour the point. It is not everything that we have to fight. She knows that at the heart of that agreement is her sector variables. She knows—*[Interruption]* Well, mainly her sector, and she knows that. But anyway, we do not have to belabour the point.

Anyway, Mr Speaker, my Colleague, the Minority Chief Whip, wants to have his bite. But may I know from the Minister whether at all the Ministry is guided by the essence of time in the matter of this blue economy.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mrs Arthur: Yes, Mr Speaker, we are guided by the urgency of time.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes?

Hon Member, let get this. Even though it is Question time—That is why I always look at the back—Once the Leader speaks, it becomes difficult for me to call somebody else. So, Hon Majority Leader, let me indulge Mr Annoh-Dompreh.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I have the attention of the Hon Minister, my Friend. Let me begin by quoting a very important portion of her answers.

“Right Hon Speaker, Ghana’s blue economy relies on the interconnectedness of water bodies (oceans and rivers), climate resilience and human wellbeing, supporting sectors such as fisheries, maritime transport, tourism, oil and gas, renewable energy as well as marine biotechnology...”

Mr Speaker, the Minister has elucidated on critical variables in the concept of blue economy development. I wish to know from my good Friend, if it is not a mere concept which is still hanging in the balance. Can the Minister tell us all the variables I spoke to, ‘climate resilience, oil and gas, interconnectedness of water bodies, oceans and rivers’, in the face of all the water pollution we are having in our country, can she itemise the achievement in these areas?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister, are you minded to respond to that Question? Very well.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, he says that I should itemise achievements that have been made in the different variables that interconnect. Mr Speaker, that is almost a full Question on its own. I may ask the House to allow me the next Question time that I get the opportunity to—*[Interruption]* He should file a Question. All right.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Hon Minority Chief Whip, I indulged you, but it is obviously a heavy duty for her. That is not why she was

brought here. You can file a Question to her if you are mindful to.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I will never challenge you, but we will have this conversation some other day.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. We turn to Question 354, and it stands in the name of the Hon Member for Atwima Nwabiagya South, Ms Shirley Kyei. Hon Member, you have the floor.

Full Operationalisation of the Anomabo Fisheries College

Ms Shirley Kyei (NPP — Atwima Nwabiagya South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture when the Anomabo Fisheries College will be fully operationalised and what academic programmes will be introduced for the first cohort in the 2025/2026 academic year?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, pursuant to the President's directive on the completion and operationalisation of the Fisheries College, measures are actively underway to complete and operationalise the Anomabo Fisheries College, a project first initiated in 2013 under the tenure of His Excellency President John Mahama. In this regard, the Ministry has awarded contracts required for the

completion of outstanding works and for the procurement of necessary office equipment, furniture, and laboratory apparatus. Additionally, a Technical Committee has been established by the Ministry to develop the administrative and governance framework for the College, as well as to recommend appropriate academic courses and programmes, the kind of college it will be and the kind of academic year that the College will apply. The Committee is expected to submit its report in due course. Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any further question?

Ms Kyei: Yes, please. The Hon Minister mentioned that contracts have been awarded for the completion of the outstanding works. Could she indicate when these contracts are expected to be completed and the College operationalised?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Yes, Hon Minister?

Mrs Arthur: Thank you very much for the question. Our intention was to have the completion by the end of this year and then operationalise as well. However, from every intent and purpose, it looks like it is likely to be the first quarter of 2026, when the remaining works will be completed and the place will be operationalised fully. Thank you very much.

Ms Kyei: Could the Hon Minister, also indicate the total cost of the remaining works? I know there was an allocation of over GHC81 million in the 2025 Budget. How much of this has been earmarked specifically for the completion and staffing and operationalisation of the College?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mrs Arthur: Thank you very much. All of that would go into the completion. Staffing was not part of the budget that was allocated. It is now that the committee that is working on curriculum development and academic and governance structure is also going to recommend to us the staffing requirements. That is when we will have a conversation on that. Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I will give you the last chance.

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker. In the Hon Minister's, response she stated that there has been a set-up of a committee for the governance and academic framework. Could she also update the House on the progress made so far with this committee, especially with regard to when the first cohorts would be admitted? Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mrs Arthur: Thank you very much. The committee was given a two-month work period. The two-month elapses end of next month, so that is when they will bring their report. As to when the first cohort will start, I cannot speak to that now because we do not have the staffing and all of those things that need to be in place for teaching and learning. I cannot speak to that yet. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Yes, Hon Member for Mfantseman?

Dr Ebenezer Prince Arhin: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I need to find out from the Minister—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I think Anomabo is in your Constituency.

Dr Arhin: Yes, Mr Speaker, it is in my Constituency.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: And the Question came from somebody else?

Dr Arhin: It is a collaboration of support to make sure that it is done. Let me commend the Hon Minister, for the great work done so far. The Minister is not only fulfilling a campaign promise, but bringing the blessings to people who are ready to go to school in that field. I want to find out from the Minister whether the scope of the construction of the university covers the Nsanfu Road that connects to the school. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes. Did you get the question?

5:05 p.m.

Mrs Arthur: Whether the project connects to a particular road, Nsanfu road, I cannot speak to that. I know that the road construction contract that has been given is the roads within the campus and from the main junction to the campus and to the principal's accommodation. But I am not sure it connects to any road outside of the project site.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to Question 355. Hon Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah, Member of Parliament (MP) for Ahafo Ano South West.

Mr Frederick Addy: — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member for Suaman?

Mr Frederick Addy: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I come under Order 88(3). I have the authority of the Hon Member to ask the Question on his behalf. Mr Speaker, may I seek your leave?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Leave granted.

Completion of Outstanding Components of Anomabo Fisheries College Infrastructure

Mr Frederick Addy on behalf of Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah (NPP — Ahafo Ano South West): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I beg to ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture the measures the Ministry has taken to ensure the

timely completion of the outstanding components of the Anomabo Fisheries College infrastructure.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Is it not the same Question?

Mr Addy: No, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right. Tell the House.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, the Question is just what I had finished answering. I do not know if I should still answer it. But the response I put here is that the Ministry has awarded contracts to finalise the remaining infrastructure at the College. The objective is to have the construction works completed by the end of the year, if possible, otherwise, by the first quarter of 2026. Construction and related activities are currently in progress.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, if that is exactly the answer let us move on. So, we turn to the Question numbered 358, Hon Gloria Owusu, MP for Trobu.

Intensification of Biosecurity Protocol in Aquaculture

Ms Gloria Owusu (NPP — Trobu): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture the steps the Ministry has taken to intensify biosecurity protocols in aquaculture,

including fish disease detection training, quality assurance and improved fish genetics.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, the Fisheries Commission, in collaboration with the Veterinary Services Directorate, strengthened fish health management through enhanced biosecurity, disease surveillance, diagnostics and control measures. A total of 612 stakeholders, including farmers, input dealers and technical officers, have been trained nationwide to improve disease prevention, early detection and response, thereby enhancing the resilience and productivity of the aquaculture sector.

In addition, to strengthen diagnostic capacity, three regional laboratories in Kumasi, Ho and Koforidua have been equipped with modern instruments through support from the Government of Norway under the Fish for Development Programme. A new Aquatic Animal Histopathology Laboratory has also been established, while the West African Centre for Cell Biology of Infectious Pathogens (WACCBIP) at the University of Ghana has been upgraded to support molecular diagnostics for timely disease detection and control.

These interventions reflect the continued resolve to strengthen disease prevention systems, protect livelihoods and enhance productivity in the aquaculture sector.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Owusu, any further questions?

Ms Owusu: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Can the Hon Minister explain how the 612 people trained have been helped to use what they have learned in their daily works?

Mrs Arthur: So, through this training, they are able to identify any signs of fish disease and they reach out to the Fisheries Commission staff, who immediately also reach out to their veterinary colleagues and what has to be done is done. It is the training that led us to identify some fish health diseases in the Ellembele district. It is through this training that action and specimen have been taken and sent abroad for investigations to understand exactly what is happening with the fish in that particular water body.

Ms Owusu: How will the Ministry continue the Fish for Development Programme after the support from Norway ends?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Did you get the question? Very well.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, I just alluded to it. The Fish Development Programme ends December, 2025. As I speak to the House now, there is a Norwegian mission in-country that are scoping to expand it to a new cooperation programme called Oceans for Development. In fact, they did an assessment, and all the gains that we have made, we are moving to the new programme and are enriching it. Fish health is featuring significantly in the

new phase that we are going to start from 2026 to 2030.

Thank you very much.

Ms Owusu: Can the Hon Minister, share some early success stories from the new diseases control measures so far?

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, I would like to come back on that at a much later date.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let us turn to Question 359, and the Question is brought to the House by Hon Gloria Owusu, MP for Trobu.

Support Packages under the Aqua/Cage-Culture Projects to Women and Youth Groups

Ms Gloria Owusu (NPP — Trobu): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. I beg to ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture the support packages being offered under the Aqua/Cage–Culture Project to women and youth groups and how equitable access to these inputs will be ensured across Districts.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, the Government aims to develop the aquaculture industry into a sector that increases domestic fish production, decreases dependence on imports, and provides employment opportunities, particularly for youth and women. However, the Ministry did not provide

support to targeted groups in 2025 due to budget constraints. Hopefully, provision would be made in the 2026 budget and the Ministry intends to prioritise equity as it places particular emphasis on youth, women and relevant institutions in the implementation across the districts of Ghana.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Ms Owusu: Thank you, Mr Speaker. How will the Ministry ensure regional balance for the support to reach all the parts of the country fairly?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: She is talking about regional balance.

Mrs Arthur: We will try as much as possible to ensure equity, as I said in my response. In the process of ensuring equity, we will try to do a regional balance. But it is important to note that there are conditions that support aquaculture growth. So, some of the regions that have more of those conditions may be served first and better. But as I said, we will ensure a balanced approach, equity, and regional balance. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Minister, will you take the last Question? The Question numbered 360 – Hon Owusu, it is enough. Question 360. Hon Rudolf Amoako-Gyampah, MP for Upper Denkyira West.

Construction Status of 157 Premix Fuel Automation Outlets

Mr Rudolf Amoako-Gyampah (NPP — Upper Denkyira West):

Thank you, Mr Speaker. I beg to ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture the status of the 157 Premix Fuel Automation outlets under construction as of the end of 2024 and the steps the Ministry is taking to ensure the completion of the remaining 143 outlets in 2025.

5:15 p.m.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, the Automated Premix Fuel Dispensing Project aims to improve transparency, efficiency, and accountability in the distribution of premix fuel to artisanal fishers. By installing automated dispensing stations with real-time monitoring systems, the project replaces the outdated manual system, which was vulnerable to diversion and abuse.

The Ministry was tasked with completing the Automated Premix Fuel Dispensing Project for 300 landing beaches across the country. By October 2025, civil works were finished at 106 sites with tanks and generators installed. Forty-six (46) of these are fully operational, while sixty (60) await calibration and testing. Civil works for the remaining 51 out of the 157 sites are at various stages of completion.

The Ministry is committed to completing and operationalising all 300 sites in 2026.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Mr Rudolf, do you have any further questions?

Mr Amoako-Gyampah: Yes, Mr Speaker?

Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Hon Minister on the specific funding source that has been earmarked for the completion of the remaining outlets and if the Minister can also tell this House if those funds have been allocated to the contractors.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mrs Arthur: The fund for this project is coming from the Government of Ghana (GoG). I inherited this project and we have revised the contract. There is an outstanding debt to the contractor. The Ministry of Finance has validated the outstanding debts and is making attempts at paying. So far as I am aware—*[Interruption]*—yes, attempts, because there is no money. The remaining will also be funded from the GoG resources.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Rudolf, are you done asking your questions?

Mr Amoako-Gyampah: No, please, I have one last one.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right, let us hear you.

Mr Amoako-Gyampah: Can the Minister tell this House if they are going to maintain the same contractor and what the timelines are, with the attempts—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Minister, are you going to maintain the same contractor?

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, I thought it was inherent in my Answer, that the contract has been revised; it is with the same contractor.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib, I saw you—

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

Hon Minister, you claim the contract has been revised, from what to what? Here, I am looking at the finances.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon Minister?

Mrs Arthur: The total contract price has been reduced by 30 per cent.

Secondly, we have been able to secure a five-year maintenance into the contract.

Thirdly, we have been able to secure the creation of an e-payment platform for the payment of premixed fuel at the pump at no cost to the Government of Ghana. There is a fourth thing that we have achieved under this new renegotiated contract.

In terms of finances, we have reduced the contract price we inherited by 30 per cent.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Mr Jerry Shaib, I would give you the last slot.

Mr Shaib: Hon Minister, what went into the reduction of the 30 per cent?

Mrs Arthur: It was a renegotiation. The contract price was too high, so we entered into a renegotiation and the contractor agreed to reduce it. We started from 10 per cent to 15 per cent and eventually arrived at 30 per cent and it was agreed. The Ministry of Finance intervened, played a role in the whole process and we managed to get the 30 per cent renegotiated cost. The new contract is being drawn.

Thank you.

Mr Shaib: I am not asking a question. I am just making a prayer, that if the Hon Minister could be requested to furnish the House with the original and revised contract—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Pray the Minister through a Question. You can bring the Minister here through a Question to come and furnish the House on that.

Hon Members, on behalf of the House, let me thank the Minister exceedingly, for appearing before the House to answer Questions from her own Colleagues and I think she has done very well in her responses.

Hon Minister, we thank you and you are hereby discharged.

Hon Members, it is time for Statements. Now, when you look at the Order Paper, the Statement to be read has been advertised. So, when you look at the page numbered 3, and the item numbered 8, the Statement to be read has been advertised. It does not mean that the Speaker cannot also admit Questions that he deems expedient. So, now we have two Statements to be read and I have also admitted one to be read today. So, we have three Statements. I hope I am clear with it. When you look at the Order Paper, the Statement to be read is now advertised.

I will call Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe, the Member for Ada, to read her Statement on the introduction of the HPV vaccine in Ghana.

STATEMENTS

Introduction of HPV Vaccine in Ghana

Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe (NDC—Ada): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make this Statement on cervical cancer and HPV vaccination in Ghana. As the Women's Caucus in the Parliament of Ghana, we stand together in full support of the national introduction of the Human Papillomavirus (HPV) vaccine into Ghana's routine immunisation programme. This milestone marks a bold step towards the protection of girls and women from cervical cancer, one of the leading causes of cancer-related deaths among Ghanaian women.

5:25 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we commend the Government of Ghana, the Ministry of Health, the Ghana Health Service, and all partners for the leadership shown in making this life-saving vaccine accessible to our dear daughters, age 9 to 14, free of charge. The HPV vaccine is not only a health intervention, it is a gender-responsive intervention, giving girls the protection they need to live long, happy lives and contribute fully to society.

Mr Speaker, it is sad to note that every year we lose over 2,000 women to cervical cancer, not because we lack medicine, but because we lack awareness, vaccine access and early screening for prompt action. When a woman is diagnosed with cervical

cancer, the impact goes far beyond her body. It affects her children, her household, her livelihood and the entire community. She may be the caregiver; the breadwinner and her illness create a ripple effect that touches everyone around her. The physical toll is often devastating, painful treatment, long hospital stays and, in many cases, late-stage diagnosis. The emotional burden includes fear, stigma and helplessness but the economic cost is even heavier.

Many families sell properties, fall into debt and lose incomes simply to keep their mothers, sisters or wives alive. To my dear women and families who have faced or are facing the pain of cervical cancer, we stand with you and hold your hands in strength and compassion. To those who have lost loved ones, please know that their memories live on in our commitment to ensure others do not walk the same path. To my brave women who are still fighting, your courage inspires us every single day. You are not alone.

Cervical cancer is a devastating disease, but it is also preventable. Together, we can protect the next generation of women and girls. We can end the silence, break the stigma and raise our voices for better access to prevention, care and hope. No woman should suffer when we can protect her from the danger. No girl should die from something we have the power to stop.

As mothers, wives, sisters and leaders, we understand the fear and myths that sometimes surround the introduction of new vaccines. Let us declare that the HPV vaccine is safe and effective. The

HPV vaccine is not entirely new in Ghana. It has long been available at a cost in private health facilities for those who can afford it. Thanks to the Government of Ghana, the vaccine is now being provided free of charge to girls aged 9 to 14 years through Ghana National Immunisation Programme from September this year.

We encourage all parents, caregivers and schools to take full advantage of this opportunity. We call on parents and caregivers to ensure their daughters receive the vaccine. Teachers and school health support teams during school vaccine session. Religious and traditional leaders use their influence to dispel misinformation and promote health-seeking behaviour. Media practitioners, promote and share accurate information and give voice to survivors and health experts. My fellow Hon Members, especially the men, should advocate in our constituencies for high uptake of the HPV vaccine and champion sustained investment in women's health and prevention of cervical cancer.

Let us unite around this cause. Let us not wait until we bury another sister, mother and friend. Let us make cervical cancer a disease of the past by ensuring every girl aged nine (9) to 14 years are vaccinated this September. Cervical cancer is preventable. The time to act is now. Protect our girls, vaccinate and save lives.

I thank you once again, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members I would admit two comments from each Side. So, I would start from Prof Ayensu-Danquah. Hon, you would not comment more than three minutes.

Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah (NDC — Essikadu-Ketan): Mr Speaker, I would like to take this opportunity to thank our great Leader, Ms Cudjoe, for this wonderful Statement.

Mr Speaker, Human Papillomavirus, also known as HPV, is a sexually transmitted disease. It is usually spread by blood and bodily fluids. It is spread from having multiple partners and also can spread from mother to child. HPV is a virus that causes cervical cancer, but it can also cause other kinds of cancers like genital warts and anal cancers. HPV infection is very insidious, only because most people who have HPV do not know they have it. And so, it is transmitted and most of them do not know they have it, and those who have been transmitted do not know they have acquired HPV until it becomes a problem. That is until one realise that they have cancer. Where the cervix is located is also not a very favourable place to find cancer so oftentimes by the time they present for medical care, it is at the end stage, or too late, and they are about to die.

Last year, we had about 3,000 cases, and over 2,500 of them have died. The mortality rate is very high for cervical cancer, only because we find it too late, and by the time we see them, there is not much we can do. So, this vaccine, is for me, one of the best things I am so excited

about being in the Ministry of Health. The vaccine is free.

HPV vaccine has been around in this country for a long time, but it is very expensive. It is about 3,000 to 5,000 a dose, and back in the day, they used to have three doses. So, people who can afford it have been buying it for their children for years now, while the poor did not have access to the vaccine. Now, the vaccine is available. It is free for every child in Ghana at 9 to 14 years old. The reason the age gap is 9 to 14 years is based on the assumption that between 9 and 14 years, the girls are not sexually active. So that by the time they get sexually active around 14, they are already immunised. So that even when they are exposed to the virus, they will not get cervical cancer.

5:35 p.m.

It is not just preventative but it is also curative. So, we are just advising mothers and women with children to vaccinate their children. This is one of the many ways we can prevent cervical cancer. Once the person gets cervical cancer there is no turning back and there is not much we can do to treat cervical cancer. So, this is an appeal to all women or all mothers in Ghana who have children between the ages of 9 and 14. The vaccine is free to every child within that age. Please vaccinate your child. My daughter who is 21 years old now was vaccinated when she was 14. So, I am confident that she will not ever have cervical cancer. I want the same for

every woman in this country. So please vaccinate your children, prevent cervical cancer and save lives.

Lastly, I would like to thank Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe again for making this wonderful Statement. We appreciate it and all the women want to say thank you.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me go to the Hon Member for Offinso North.

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, and let me appreciate the maker of the Statement regarding the HPV vaccine to prevent cervical cancer. As earlier stated, you would want one to be vaccinated to build up the immune system to prevent any kind of exposure and it is known that it best works if you are done with the doses by age 13. That is why we are recommending that you start by the age of nine. This is also to warn men that tend to prey on young girls who have not been given said vaccine and tend to force them to sleep with them.

Mr Speaker, HPV is a silent killer and many times most women do not know their status. In fact, not all women have gone to their doctors to be screened for it— even women in their forties. So now that the vaccine is free, we want to encourage that all Ghanaian women as much as possible should get tested for the HPV exposure and if possible, the

Ministry of Health should be working with the Ministry of Education so that our young ones that are getting to the lower primary, upper primary and junior secondary school are all lined up because we are now being told that it is free. So, if it is free then there should be a programme to make sure that as much as possible all young Ghanaian women within the ages of 9 and 14 are given this vaccine with the permission of their parents because it is a vaccine and as far as it is a vaccine definitely there might be some few risks. So, it is very important that parents in Ghana consent to this vaccination for their young girls so that we can prevent any kind of cervical cancer. Even though there is not an established study to link HPV to breast cancer, there are still more studies ongoing and we want to prevent any kind of cancer.

So please, now that it is free, our encouragement is for people to do that and for me I will make sure I engage the people of Offinso North from Nkwankwa to Afrancho and the Education Directorate to make sure that we get our young ones vaccinated just to prevent this kind of infection in the near future.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me call the Chairman of the Health Committee.

Dr Mark Kurt Nawaane (NDC — Nabdām): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity and I also want to acknowledge the maker of the Statement.

In my private practice, I have met a lot of such cases and when I started practising, we did not to give this vaccine that we are giving today. It appears the people usually come a bit late with the genital warts. And I must say that the reason cases of the cervical cancer were high is that most of them had some form of stigma regarding their genital warts. When they come to the hospital and they have it until it gets very severe and it is itching, sometimes it grows on the vulva and even try to cover part of the vaginal orifice— And when they start getting complications like not being able to have sex or when they are not able to hide it from their partners, that is when they will probably talk to the doctor about it.

When I ask them their reason for not coming to the hospital, they will say that they are even hiding those warts from their partners. And that is why they report very late on these issues to the medical doctors or to the health professionals. And in view of that, some of them request for surgical removal of the warts. And when you tell them that is not the final solution, they still might go to another doctor who will do that type of thing for them and give them some form of conservative treatment. But they will come with the complications. They will later come with cervical bleeding, changes on the cervix and precancerous lesions and that is when you will realise that the patient is presenting the situation very late.

I am happy that we have the vaccine this time and as it is said, catch them young so between the ages of 9 and 14 is very early. We only need to explain to the parents that it is not harmful to the

girl child and I believe most parents would take them for the vaccine. So, I call on our mothers and fathers to listen to the Government. It is a good programme and they should send their girl child between the ages of 9 and 14 for the vaccine.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me come to Leadership.

5:45 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have just a simple contribution to make on this matter. Fortunately, the Deputy Minister for Health is here. If HPV vaccines are being made free, I do not think the statistics of the infection is anywhere close to Hepatitis B, which is taking more than 10 per cent of the population. According to Ghana Health Services data, more than three million of Ghanaians are infected by the Hepatitis B virus.

It attacks the liver and eventually leads to liver cancer.

Mr Speaker, it is good that these vaccines are being administered to address this cervical cancer situation. But let us use the same haste to introduce free vaccination and treatment for Hepatitis B.

Mr Speaker, without more, I would want to rest my case.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Members.

Yes, Hon Deputy Majority Leader, you want to say something?

Deputy Majority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity, and I also thank the maker of the Statement.

Mr Speaker, it is obvious that prevention is always better than cure. The HPV vaccine is going to save lives and save money in the long run because we know living with and treating cancer can be a very expensive thing to do. So, if this vaccine is taken at the right age can actually prevent the progression of cervical cancer, then it is a good thing. I mean, in the past, this vaccine has always been there as I understand it. But because of the cost, the women were not taking it because they could not afford it. It then progresses and becomes a more expensive thing.

Now that it is free, we need to encourage the right age group as the vaccine is supposed to prevent the cancer from happening and not have it when the cancer has already advanced. So, it is important that we have the right education, the right awareness to make sure that the ladies at the right age have this vaccine to prevent the cost to themselves in the future and actually a cost to the state.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to thank the maker of the Statement

again for this important statement. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, we have the second Statement that has been advertised and it is in the name of the Hon Member for Kwabre East, Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Achampong. He is not here, therefore, I will ask the Hon Minority Chief Whip to read his Statement.

So, Hon Minority Chief Whip, Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh, you may read the Statement now.

Transforming Urban Ghana: Evidence-Based Solutions for Sustainable, Clean, and Resilient Cities

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (NPP—Nsawam-Adoagyiri): Mr Speaker, there comes a defining moment in the life of every nation when progress can no longer be measured by the grandeur of its skylines or the length of its highways, but by the harmony it achieves between humanity and nature. Ghana stands today at that crossroads. Our cities, once symbols of vitality and promise, are straining under the weight of their own success. The streets of Accra, Kumasi, Takoradi, and Tamale throb with energy and ambition, yet beneath this vitality lies a deepening crisis of congestion, pollution, and urban neglect.

Across the world, cities have become the beating hearts of national economies, magnets of opportunity, innovation, and growth. Ghana is no exception. From Accra to Kumasi, Tamale to Takoradi, our cities are expanding at a pace that

outstrips our ability to manage their environmental, social, and infrastructural demands.

Mr Speaker, according to the Ghana Statistical Service (2021), over 56.7 per cent of Ghanaians now live in urban areas, up from 50.9 per cent in 2010. By 2030, that number is projected to surpass 60 per cent, placing immense pressure on land, water, air, and housing. While cities contribute over 70 per cent of Ghana's Gross Domestic Product (GDP), they also generate more than 12,000 tonnes of solid waste daily, of which only about 70 per cent is collected and even less is properly treated. The World Bank (2020) estimates that poor sanitation, pollution, and waste mismanagement together cost Ghana nearly 3 per cent of GDP annually, a staggering economic loss that directly undermines public health, productivity, and tourism.

Mr Speaker, urban air quality, particularly in Accra, has reached critical levels. The Environmental Protection Authority (EPA, 2023) attributes about 40 per cent of Accra's Particulate Matter 2.5 (PM_{2.5}) air pollution to road transport emissions. This makes respiratory diseases among the top five causes of outpatient visits in the Greater Accra Region. As Ghana's urban population swells, unregulated vehicular emissions, congested markets, unmanaged waste, and disappearing green spaces are eroding the livability of our cities.

If this trajectory continues unchecked, by 2040, Accra could host more than 7 million people, living amid worsening traffic congestion, frequent flooding,

rising temperatures, and declining air quality. The cost to the national economy, and to the wellbeing of future generations, will be incalculable.

Learning from Global Examples: Pathways to Urban Renewal

Mr Speaker, Ghana is not alone in facing these challenges. Many nations have walked similar paths and charted transformative blueprints that now serve as beacons of possibility. Kigali, Rwanda stands as a leading African example. Once plagued by disorganised growth, Kigali implemented a strict urban master plan (2020/2050) anchored in sanitation enforcement, efficient waste collection, and green public spaces. Today, Kigali is recognised as one of Africa's cleanest and most orderly capitals, attracting tourism and sustainable investment. Its success lies in political will, community participation, and citywide enforcement, three ingredients Ghana can replicate within its metropolitan and municipal assemblies.

Mr Speaker, in Singapore, Asia's urban miracle rests on meticulous planning and integration of green design into the urban fabric. Its "City in Nature" strategy under the Green Plan 2030 has increased urban greenery, expanded public transport electrification, and promoted "15-minute neighbourhoods" where residents can live, work, and relax within walking distance. Cities in Ghana, particularly Accra and Kumasi, can adopt this approach by legislating mandatory green quotas in new

developments, incentivising rooftop gardens, and linking urban planning with public health and climate action.

Mr Speaker, Copenhagen, Denmark offers Europe's most enduring model of sustainable urban mobility. By investing in protected cycling lanes and pedestrian-friendly infrastructure, the city has made cycling account for over 35 per cent of all daily trips.

5:55 p.m.

Air pollution levels have dropped dramatically, and public satisfaction with urban life remains among the highest in the world. For Ghana, this translates into the urgent need to create non-motorised transport corridors and bus rapid transit systems to reduce congestion, improve health, and cut carbon emissions.

Contextualising Ghana's Path Forward

The solutions to Ghana's urban crisis are within reach, practical, measurable, and achievable within coordinated policy leadership and public accountability.

First and foremost, greening our cities must become a cornerstone of national urban policy. Metropolitan assemblies can increase tree canopy over 10-15 per cent within the next decade and reserve at least 12 per cent of new development areas for green and open spaces. Pocket parks and river buffer zones can

transform flood-prone areas into ecological assets and also serve as public recreation spaces.

Mr Speaker, secondly, Ghana must transition toward clean and inclusive urban transport. This requires modernising *trotro* fleets, piloting electric buses on major corridors like Kasoa-Accra and Adum-Sofo Line, and expanding pedestrian and cycling infrastructure. Cleaner mobility will directly reduce air pollution, improve productivity, and align Ghana's transport sector with its Nationally Determined Contributions (the NDCs), under the Paris Agreement.

Mr Speaker, furthermore, we must decongest public spaces such as markets and lorry terminals through structured spatial planning. Establishing multi-level market complexes, recognising trading zones and scheduling delivery hours can ease congestion while protecting livelihoods. Modern terminals at the city peripheries, supported by feeder buses, can further declutter the urban core.

Finally, proper waste management is indispensable. Ghana should move from collection-only systems to a circular waste economy with recycling cooperatives, material recovery facilities, and composting plants that create green jobs for our safeguarding environment. Achieving some 50 per cent diversion from landfill by 2030 is both feasible and economically smart.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, the future of Ghana's cities will not be determined by chance, but by the courage of our choices. If we build without foresight, we will inherit congestion, pollution, and decay. But if we build with a purpose guided by ecological wisdom, justice, and innovation, we will create cities that breathe, move, and heal.

Let us, therefore, chart a bold national agenda for green, healthy, and inclusive cities. And that harmonises economic ambition with environmental stewardship and transforms Ghana's urban spaces into symbols of resilience and pride. Like Kigali, Singapore, and Copenhagen, our success will depend not on the size of our budgets, but on the strength of our vision and the discipline of our governance. Ghana stands ready for this transformation. The time to green our cities and secure the well-being of generations to come is now.

The destiny of our cities is in the destiny of our nation. The choices we make today will echo far beyond this generation. We can continue to build without conscience, piling concrete upon concrete. Or we can build with wisdom, creating cities that reflect the balance between progress and preservation, ambition and accountability.

History teaches us that cities are not merely fiscal spaces. They are a moral statement about who we are and what we value. Kigali has shown that discipline and civic pride can transform a city once burdened by its past into a beacon of

order and cleanliness. Singapore demonstrates that foresight and integrated planning can turn a small island into one of the world's most liveable urban spaces. Copenhagen reminds us that sustainability and modernity coexist. That clean air and economic vitality are not opposites but partners.

Mr Speaker, Ghana, too, can chart this path. If we green our streets, reform our transport, manage our waste wisely, and plan our settlement with human dignity, let this House and this generation be remembered as those who refused to accept decay as destiny. Let us be remembered as the sewers who planted trees of foresight, built corridors of equity, and designed cities of hope. For in the final measure, the true greatness of a nation is not found in its monument of steel, but in the liveability of cities and the sustainability of its own.

I thank you, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, I think your Statement is too long —[*Laughter*]. You have advocated that Statements that are brought to the House should not go beyond two pages. So please, let us adhere to that.

At times, if the Statements are too long, Members become bored while listening to them. This is not in respect to what Hon Leader just read, but it is a general statement I am making. It is

something that we have said here over and over again.

So let us ensure that our Statement is concise. I will admit comments from each Side, then I will come to Leadership. Yes, I have not heard the ladies speak today.

Yes, Hon Member for Salaga South?

Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah (NDC — Salaga South): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, let me start by commending my Colleague, the Minority Chief Whip, for this very brilliant and deep Statement that he has made today. I would confess, that some of the issues he has raised in the Statement have agitated my mind for a very long time. I think I never really sat down to put pen to paper, and I want to commend him for that. The Statement is timely, and if we listen, the better for all of us.

Mr Speaker, my Colleague made references to Kigali and Singapore. I heard him also make reference to other civilisations. As we speak, I am happy that Hon Gizella Tetteh-Agbotui, Deputy Minister for Works and Housing, is in the Chamber today. Recently, I was with her in Addis Ababa, and the trip took us from our hotel to the African Union (AU) headquarters, we talked about nothing but town development. We discussed why we could not do what they are doing in Addis Ababa.

Mr Speaker, I had been there five years before, and when I went there this time, I did not recognise the city. They are building the city, and they are conscious of the road; there are about three or four lane roads in Addis, with walkways where pedestrians can also walk, and maybe she can help with the measurements, but I saw that the walkways were equal to one road. It is not these corner things that we do in this country. Space! And we saw couples holding hands and walking, and we saw Ethiopians walking in their city.

Mr Speaker, we do not walk in this country because there is nowhere to walk. If we attempt to walk from Afrikiko to 37 or in front of the Presidency, a car will knock us down because there are no pavements, and street hawkers have taken the road, and so no one is thinking about the other person. It cannot all be about vehicles. We need the space.

Mr Speaker, the other thing we saw, consciously, is the Median. I used to call it an island, until Hon Gizella told me it is called the Median. Trees are planted in the median to provide shade and protect the environment.

6:05 p.m.

In Ghana, we put concrete and pavement stones, and the next thing, you go there—My cousin has money to pull his wheelbarrow, and he is selling slippers, toothpaste, and toothbrushes on the road—in the middle of the road, in this country. It only happens in this

country. Now they have even upgraded it. They lay out the slippers in different shades and colours. Every time I drive and I see that scene, I ask myself, so if I see a slipper that I want, am I going to park in the middle of the road and get down and walk, or will I now find space outside the road, park and cross? So, there is just something wrong with us and something wrong with our planning. The earlier we admit it, the better.

Mr Speaker, in Dubai, in the Midian, there are trees growing, a desert country. We are here; we have fertile lands but we are so quick to pull down a tree when we are building a house. At the least opportunity, we pull down a tree, and we build a house. What are our environmentalists doing? What is the Forestry Commission doing? In the United Kingdom, you cannot pull down a tree until you have permission from the local council. And you have to pay. They will examine the condition and make sure that indeed, the tree needs to come down, and you pay for the felling of the tree. We need to begin to look at—When we speak, we are told that we have all the laws in this country. So, we ask yourselves, where are the laws? Did we make the laws for the shelves, or we made the laws so we can become better?

Mr Speaker, we were in Kigali, and we found that the Local Government Ministry is the ministry that runs the country. Every sector has to send their budget through the Local Government Ministry. The Local Government Ministry has to ensure that their programmes and activities align with the needs of the local people. They then

forward it to the Finance Ministry before the budgets are approved. Mr Speaker, what is the story in this country? In this country, I do not think anyone even takes the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs into account when we are developing programmes and activities in our districts.

Thank you very much, Mr Annoh-Dompseh. Let us get talking and let us ask for action. We do not have to go and reinvent the wheel. It is not rocket science; it is just trying to copy. I like to use that word. Just go and copy what they are doing there and come and do it here.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Hon Members, it is a very important Statement, but let me urge you to at least limit your comment within three minutes. Please.

Yes, let me go to the Hon Member for Suame.

Mr John Darko (NPP — Suame): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I want to thank the maker of the statement, Mr Annoh-Dompseh, for this very insightful Statement. In fact, as the Vice Chair of the Committee on Environment, Science and Technology, I believe I am obliged to at least say one or two words about his Statement on the Floor.

The Statement for me is one of the most impactful Statements I have listened to on the floor of this House. The maker of the Statement identified all the problems our cities face and not only that, he also proffered solutions. I believe

that if this Statement is to be admitted and worked on by the various ministries, our problems as a country or the cities will be resolved. The Hon Member mentioned air quality. Indeed, our cities are polluted. From Accra to Kumasi to Tamale to Bolgatanga, our cities are polluted. The Hon Member also mentioned and attributed that to vehicle emissions. There is no question about that, that vehicle emissions is one of the sources of air pollution in our country. That is why I believe that it is important that Government policy on the importation of electric vehicles should be encouraged. The previous government led this charge and imported a lot of electric vehicles to transport our people. It looks to me the attention on that has gone down. So, I will urge the current administration to pay attention to the electric vehicle policy.

When I speak about electric vehicles, I must always bring in my constituency because my constituency is the hub of combustion engine vehicle repair and maintenance. It is a source of livelihood for our people, Suame Constituency. Once we are talking about bringing in electric vehicles to combat air pollution, we must also look at the fact that a lot of people are going to lose their jobs when the combustion engine vehicles are no longer in vogue. So, we have to find a way to help them as well.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Member also spoke about waste management. I think it is so important that we discuss waste management. Our cities are choked, and I know of course, Accra and Kumasi, and especially, in the heart of our city,

Kumasi, Adum and Kejetia, the way waste is treated leaves much to be desired. Once the Hon Member has mentioned it and has proffered solution, I want to add that in this country, we have companies that have set up integrated recycling and compost plants that we must encourage and also ensure that they are able to fix this problem for us.

Mr Speaker, maybe one minute just to address the greening of our cities. I recommend and beg the Metropolitan, Municipal, and District Assemblies (MMDAs) to ensure that when they are giving out building permits, the applicants will make sure that they plant greens and trees in their homes. It should be a prerequisite for granting building permits. I am sure once that is done, the green problem will also be solved. Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me go the Hon Member for the Guan Constituency.

Mr Fred Kwesi Agbenyo (NDC—Guan): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement that was ably made by the Minority Chief Whip. The issue of health in our country is a serious one and has been discussed on several platforms. I believe almost all of us here are getting fatigued discussing this particular subject matter. As the earlier speaker said, nations across the world have managed their communities and planned their communities very well. All of us travel across the world and we see how they have managed their cities. I am still

wondering why it is so difficult for us as a people to just adopt and implement same in our country.

Mr Speaker, waste management even in the national capital itself is a problem. You go to the so-called elite communities, East Legon and the rest, and then you see dustbins in front of people's houses, and for days, nobody has come to pick their garbage from the house. It is something we see across every place. So, Mr Speaker, I think that we need to refer this particular Statement to the appropriate institutions, so we try to find a lasting solution to the issue of waste management. Now, one would argue that Accra Central and most parts of Accra are old cities, so we cannot do much about it. The question is the new settlements that are coming up, what is the town and Country Planning Department doing? This is because the expectation would have been that before people even moved to a new area, the road infrastructure would have been developed, water would have been extended to the place, electricity and water would have been there, so that the city is well planned. Unfortunately, even the new settlements that are coming up, the same problems that we are facing with the old ones are the same that we are experiencing there too. So, we sit back and ask ourselves, who is in charge of the country? Who is in charge of the city planning? Are the people really working, and why are we paying them if they are not doing the right thing?

Mr Speaker, we can cite examples across the world of how nations have developed. If we refuse to implement our

by-laws and refuse to punish people, and that we wait to occasionally come and make Statements like this and leave it at that, we are not going to see any improvement in this country. Mr Speaker, we have been doing afforestation every now and then, and sometimes we wonder.

If we are constructing roads, we would expect that just around 37 Military Hospital, the manner in which they were able to leave trees in the middle of the road, we would do the same in some other places, yet we put the trees down at the least thing.

6:15 p.m.

We would do the same in some other places, yet we put the trees down at the least thing. So, Mr Speaker, once again, thank you very much for the opportunity. Let me also thank the maker of the Statement.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Dr Mahama?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I would also like to commend the consistency of the Minority Chief Whip with which he is pursuing this matter of urban planning. In the last meeting of this Parliament, a similar Statement was presented by the respected Minority Chief Whip, highlighting the matter in issue and bringing our attention to the need for us to do something about how we plan our cities.

Mr Speaker, I want to associate myself with the various speakers on this matter and with the examples of cities that they have highlighted. He mentioned Kigali and Singapore, but I would want to add another city, which we should actually add to our reflection on how they have been able to develop, Mr Speaker, Curitiba. Curitiba is a southern Brazilian —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Where?

Dr Mahama: Curitiba, C-u-r-i-t-i-b-a. It is a southern Brazilian city. Mr Speaker, some years ago in urban development planning, this was a case every student in urban planning would learn on, how the urban regeneration was done in Curitiba. At the heart of their development initiative was what they called Integrated Sustainable Planning of the city, where they factor in natural development into their development programme. It was anchored on what they called the Radial Linear Branching Pattern.

What they basically did was that they directed development along transportation corridors, and once development was directed along transportation corridors, they were able to plan their city. They were also able to introduce what they called the Green Initiative, which the respected Member for Salaga South, also highlighted why we should not be in a hurry to pull down trees in our haste to develop.

Mr Speaker, they also introduced what is called the Bus Rapid Transit (BRT) system. Mr Speaker, we are dealing with Metro Mass Transit, Aayalolo Bus

Transit, we are now introducing electric bus, but we have not been able to consistently manage this transportation system. Recently, we attempted creating dedicated lanes for the Bus Rapid Transit system. Mr Speaker, if we take the Accra and Nsawam roads, those lanes were created, but they have become eyesores now. They have virtually been encroached, and public buses that are not supposed to be using these lanes are now using those lanes.

Once we make attempts to develop our cities along the lines of the developed countries, and the case studies we have highlighted, why are we not able to sustain them, Mr Speaker? Is it the culture that we are not yet used to that system? We must begin to reorient ourselves towards how we can make this part of our conscience.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I would want to say that in this particular initiative, if we prioritise social equity as the baseline for urban re-planning or urban regeneration, we will be able to get it right. The poor man does not understand what it means to be orderly, because at the heart of it, is survival. If they were going to break the laws and be insensitive about the environment in order to survive, they would. But once we factor social re-engineering and social equity into the urban planning process, I am sure we will—

Mr Speaker, I want to thank the maker of the Statement and the contributors for this brilliant Statement. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I think I said two on each Side, but I am inclined to give the Hon Deputy Minister for Works, Housing and Water Resources the opportunity to also make a comment. Yes, Hon Gizella Tetteh-Agbotui?

Mrs Gizella Akushika Tetteh-Agbotui (NDC — Awutu Senya West): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am grateful. Mr Speaker, I wish to thank my senior Colleague — senior in the House, not in age though — Hon Annoh-Dompreh, for this insightful Statement. It is always refreshing for us to sometimes go beyond our partisan lines and discuss things that are actually beneficial for the country.

We all have our individual visions as Members of Parliament for our districts and our constituencies. So, if we break it down into smaller pieces, which actually we individually dream of in our constituencies, I am sure that we will be able to try and implement some best practices in some of the components that he has talked about. For example, one thing that we could do across the board is discipline. Mr Speaker, without discipline, we can implement the greenest plans and the smartest cities, but we will not be able to go far because of indiscipline and us not being able to appreciate the beauty in having such interventions in our cities.

Mr Speaker, let me give a typical example. Under our Ministry, we often have challenges with flooding. We oversee certain aspects of infrastructure in this country. The drains that are designed by our implementing partners and agencies are not meant to carry

rubbish; they are meant for water and water has a volume. But we realise that almost all the drains are going to have to carry water, silt and some rubbish. Essentially, three things are being carried in one drain that actually should have just contained one. In other countries, they just contain one, which is water. So, there is a lot that we have to do to improve, aside our urban planning, our urban implementation of all the programmes that we have.

So, it is my prayer that as Members of Parliament, as we are all ex-officio members of our district assemblies, we will be able to hammer on improvements in development control. Mr Speaker, just about two weeks ago, I was privileged to take some classes with the Metropolitan, Municipal District Chief Executives (MMDCEs) and I discussed some of these things that are important to our districts. We all want to leave legacies one day and we are hoping that we will be able to implement the right policies and right programmes for them.

Mr Speaker, the example of Ethiopia cannot be overlooked. It is an African country and their green legacy initiative is something worth emulating. The previous government had the Green Ghana Project, we have got Tree for Life Initiative, but it seems that we take them as smaller programmes. In a day, Ethiopians planted 355 million seedlings. Over the past five or six years, they now have billions. They did that also because they realised that there was desertification approaching. With that massive injection of trees, they were able to reverse that. When we go there, we

would see that the weather pattern has even changed.

Mr Speaker, trees give us green cover. They lower temperatures, improve weather conditions, beautify our cities, remove Carbon dioxide (CO₂) and they improve on other areas that are facing desertification, like I said. Mr Speaker, I just hope that as Members of Parliament, we will start small in our constituencies. We should take just one town that we wish had a different image to what it is today. If it means that we just plant a thousand trees, we will see the difference that will make in about five years. When we are able to plant even just that, and make that difference, other things will follow. People will start seeing the beauty of the green, and then they will start cleaning up their environments as well. I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. I will end with Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah.

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah (NPP — Ofoase Ayirebi): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make a few remarks in support of the Statement that has been made by the Minority Chief Whip.

Mr Speaker, Hon Colleagues may be interested in knowing that this area of green energy and urban regeneration is an area of academic and professional interest for him. So, we would find that his Statements on this subject are always rich and well researched, and we celebrate him for that.

Mr Speaker, one of the points that he makes that is very interesting is the fact that urbanisation is growing by about 7 per cent between 2010 and 2021 in Ghana. It is growing for a number of reasons. The economy is one, political and administrative causes are another, social reasons are also another. But another reason, Mr Speaker, is the absence of deep rural planning and rural investment. Because we are not doing a lot of rural planning and rural investment, urbanisation is also being quickened, because everybody wants to go to a place where they would get a lot more services, infrastructure, facilities, *et cetera*.

Mr Speaker, one of the periods in which Ghana saw a lot of investment and perhaps even the mainstreaming of this rural development agenda was between 1969 and 1972, the era of Mr Kofi Abrefa Busia, when a major rural development programme commenced in this country.

6:25 p.m.

Mr Speaker, one of the components was rural housing. I just heard the Deputy Minister for Works and Housing speak. I do know that, for example, one of the programmes at the Ministry is a District Housing Programme, which is aimed at going back heavily to reinvest in our districts in a manner that quickens economic activity, slows down rural-urban migration, *et cetera*.

Mr Speaker, my contribution is that we need to deepen how much funding we make available for rural investment, and in particular for district investment and district housing. Because when we are able to do that, the kind of investment

that one requires in the districts to make people more comfortable, to engage in all sorts of economic activities, and to progress there is enhanced. So, from my point of view, I think that resource availability for investment in the districts should continue. I see the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, and I hear him very often trying to make arguments for an improvement in the resource mobilisation that should go there. I think it is one of the things that we need to pay attention to if rural or district investment would succeed and this will help slow down the rate at which we are migrating to the regional capitals.

Another matter is the rate of project execution. Sometimes, we have monies voted for investment projects in the districts and in the rural areas, but the rate at which we execute these projects is also a matter of worry. It does not matter how much money we vote, if the absorptive capacity is low, and projects are not being executed in accordance with these timelines, we would not achieve much.

Finally, again, as the Deputy Minister for Works and Housing mentioned, and as has been mentioned by some of our other Colleagues, there needs to be a lot more enforcement when it comes to management, whether of the rural or urban areas, so that the kind of, may I say, designs that we have in mind and the infrastructure that we have laid out would be able to serve its purpose.

Mr Speaker, once again, I commend the maker of the Statement and our

Colleagues who have contributed to it. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Now, Leadership?

Mr Ahmed Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, honestly, I am speaking as a Minister but on behalf of Leadership, but if I win your favour, I would have pleaded that I would need this specific *Hansard* for action in my Ministry. This specific *Hansard* which contains this Statement. Because of that, if Mr Speaker would not mind, I would love the Minister for Education and the Prof in Environment, Prof Hamza—Mr Speaker, this is what is expected of Parliament, where Parliament speaks and it informs policy and decisions on the Executive. But this is one of the best, and excellent researched Statements presented on this Floor.

Mr Speaker, if you would not mind—We are still in your hands, I would love to listen to them. If I should proceed when I finish, then you give them the opportunity— Because I would be coming for copies of the *Hansard* anyway.

Thank you.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I corroborate the appeal of the Minister? This is how the practice has been. Since he is a sector minister, we should allow the other Members to contribute and then the Minister would speak last. That has been the practice.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

But I do not think I can entertain all the people who are so desirous to speak. So, let me indulge the Minister for Education. Then—you would not. I want you to speak because we need to also inculcate school children in this habit of discipline, tree planting *et cetera*. That is why I want you to also have a bite on the Statement.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, thank you for your indulgence.

I would endeavour to be very brief, and to commend the maker of the Statement, Mr Annoh-Dompreh, the Minority Chief Whip, on the Statement, Transforming Urban Ghana: Evidence-Based Solutions for Sustainable, Clean, and Resilient Cities.

Mr Speaker, I commend him, indeed, this is an evidence-based Statement. It looks academic and it is also intellectual. But Mr Speaker, to comment on few areas, when we look at Accra, Kumasi, Takoradi and Tamale; we are just focusing on four prime cities. There are other cities with equal measures of the same problem; over-congestion, environmental pollution, lack of tree planting and destruction of those trees. Mr Speaker, when the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs gets the opportunity to come to this House, how does he ensure that the District Assemblies Common Fund (DA CF) is well allocated so as to be guided by actionable policies? We do not expect that Bodi in Sefwi would be compared to Kumasi, Tamale or Takoradi.

Mr Speaker, again, some districts like Tema have port cities. This gives them advantage in terms of resource mobilisation and so we cannot compare it to a district in Fomena. So, how do we do equalisation in terms of resource mobilisation and allocation? We have to consider that. So, if we have to share resources, it makes sense to give Walewale more than Tema, Takoradi, Tamale, and Ofoase Ayirebi. It makes sense since they may need more.

Mr Speaker, this is a very brilliant Statement. He gives the example of Kigali, and I just shared this personal experience. I travelled from Ethiopia to Kigali some time ago when I was a diplomat. At the Ethiopian airport, I bought a veil for my mother then, in a black polythene bag. When I arrived in Kigali, I was told that that bag would not enter Kigali, notwithstanding my standing as the Minister's Diplomat. I had to take the veil from the bag. This is discipline.

In Ghana, when everybody gets sachet water, we drink and throw it away. What do we expect? That is pollution; a very dangerous pollution. Are we taking a decision on the future of plastics? For instance, I have been directed by the President that “do not use wood for furniture. Go and explore ways you can use plastic waste to produce furniture”. Are we able to do that?

So, Mr Speaker, I like his reference to many of those cities. If we take Singapore or South Korea, countries that are peers to Ghana. We are told that literacy in South Korea is now 98 per cent. Today, Ghana is still around 79 per cent. The per capita income in South Korea is about US\$30,000 but Ghana's is still at US\$2,500 but we started with

them. When one flies to Kumasi, one likes the spatial planning of Kumasi but we cannot say the same for Tamale. When one lands in Tamale, there are a lot of unstructured and planned homes. So, we all need to be guided. They must respect policy decisions on spatial planning in the country. In Ghana, people enjoy even building on waterways. Why would we build on a waterway? Is it because we think that we are strong and powerful? No. We have seen school football pitches being converted to other things. This is unacceptable.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, I share in the Hon Member's view that we should encourage tree planting. When we go to Turkey, they also have vehicular congestion but what they do is that they have an effective traffic management system, which is IT-driven. So, the police unit, which is responsible for traffic, would know at this hour that there is congestion on the motorway. Then they would block the roads and divert traffic—Just create a new passageway to decongest.

6:35 p.m.

Ghana is capable of doing that. When you go to Turkey, there is a traffic management system and we need a more effective and efficient one than what we have in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, finally, let us come to Ghana. We all travel abroad and we see their rush hours. The problem of the workers in Ghana is just in three-fold. First, what all the workers in this country need is for the state to invest well in shelter and housing for them. Then, in

transport, when you go everywhere in America, you can even be living in Washington while working in New York because there is an effective transport system of train and then by air and maybe your income matches that. But in Ghana, we all know that at 4:30 p.m., when you walk through Accra, you would see the congestions. What is the state doing? You will see workers stranded. They are just looking for a means to get home and get home on time.

Then, that leads finally, Mr Speaker, to our roads. I just got back from Kumasi this afternoon. When you are in Kumasi, there is congestion and it is because we have not opened up the city, yet it is one of the fastest growing cities in the country – the Green City. We have not invested in Kumasi roads. From the airport to Lancaster where the German President was hosted, you have to be struggling through traffic. We need to do more in expanding the road infrastructure of these cities: Accra, Kumasi, Tamale and Takoradi. If you are entering Takoradi, the overhead bridge started under SinoHydro is uncompleted. Where is the discipline? What happened?

Mr Speaker, I would to want to commend the Hon Member for a very academic – this one looks like the Hon Member was writing a thesis to be awarded something else. But I would like to thank him at least for bringing this matter to fore but Parliament has a role in the way we allocate resources, not just the District Assemblies Common Fund.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

So, Prof Hamza, I will give you just two minutes, please.

Prof Hamza Adam (NDC — Kumbungu): Thank you so much, Mr Speaker, for indulging me and to thank the maker of the Statement for a very comprehensive and detailed submission. Mr Speaker, the planning aspect has been detailed and discussed by Colleagues. An important aspect that I think that I may want to address is the waste aspect of that. Solid waste is a serious menace we have to deal with as a country. If you walk in the communities, you will see mountains of solid waste and the waste does not occur in a vacuum. It is as a result of the attitude of the individuals, which we have to tackle head on as a country. Aside the nuisance that the solid waste brings, we also have a lot of diseases that are coming from the waste; Malaria, typhoid, and some other diseases are occurring as a result of the waste.

There is also another dimension to it. The solid waste we see also generates greenhouse gas, which is methane, a more potent, about 86 times more than that of carbon dioxide. And so, it is a dangerous greenhouse gas generated by the solid waste. It is important that we

look at it as a country and see how we will manage solid waste.

In conclusion, as a country, it is important to strengthen the bylaws and the laws to work in this country. Because I know that our laws have comprehensively captured how we will deal with those who drop waste anyhow but enforcement has been a challenge. Let us look at it as a country on how we will ensure that we deal with those who flout the regulations.

Mr Speaker, the other thing is sensitisation. We have to step up our advocacy drive to ensure that we do a lot of communication to sensitise people on the dangers of dropping solid anyhow, so that we can deal with it as a country. Mr Speaker, just a minute to conclude, the other aspect is technology. We have to look at how we will introduce technology in managing our waste. The issue of reuse and recycling is a matter that we have to look at. Finally, EPA is decentralising, in their bid to managing the waste and so they are trying to widen their presence by introducing district offices of EPA to deal with this. I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. So, Hon Jerry.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP — Weija-Gbawe): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity. In mounting my own views on this matter,

not for me to sound repetitive, but let me take this opportunity to highly commend the maker of this Statement in the person of Hon Frank Annoh-Dompreh, the Minority Chief Whip. This is a very profound Statement.

Mr Speaker, just pardon me to repeat this, which for me has caught my attention largely and I read: “There comes a defining moment in the life of every nation when progress can no longer be measured by the grandeur of its skylines or the length of its highways, but by the harmony it achieves between humanity and nature.”

Mr Speaker, 31st October happened to have been the World Cities Day themed “Promoting People-Centred Smart Cities”, which is just in line with what the Minority Chief Whip has delivered, transforming urban Ghana.

Mr Speaker, as I listened to Colleagues and the maker of the Statement himself, I have also catalogued a few reasons why Ghana and most cities in Ghana are undergoing some sort of trouble. Like the Minister for Education said, and just in consonance with what the Minority Chief Whip said on the issue of congestion. I have worked as far back as 2001 to 2006 in the city of Accra, as an aide to the then Mayor of Accra, Hon

Stanley Nii Adjiri Blankson. When he announced cleaning the city, making the city of Accra one of the best places that one can find himself or herself. Mr Speaker, what happens? There is always the lack of political will. One person will put in resources, energy and everything. There will be sleepless nights. You will go and clear the hawkers and the traders on the roads and on the pavements.

Let there be a by-election or a situation that will call for a political decision. And Mr Speaker, do you know what you will see? You will see the same politician who had then removed people from the streets and pavements, now giving orders for people to come back. Hon Stanley Nii Adjiri Blankson suffered and did not sleep. The staff of Accra Metropolitan Assembly (AMA), the police and the military were all on the roads and the streets of Accra just to clean Accra. Work was well executed. When there was a by-election, there were suggestions from above.

President Mahama must be commended for saying that he has formed a task force. But Mr Speaker, as we speak, I can tell you on authority that that task force is virtually moribund. We are not seeing actions. What we are seeing is the true settings. We go to places where they are overly congested and largely when you go, you end up

seeing party apparatchiks. And Mr Speaker, do you know what happens? The Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs would be called to withdraw. The Municipal Chief Executive (MCE) or the Mayor of that city will be called to withdraw so there is less activity in dealing with all these issues.

Mr Speaker, when you come to my Constituency in Weija-Gbawe, there are Ramsar sites in Dansoman. These Ramsar sites are being filled and human beings are building in waterways but Mr Speaker, who are you to talk? Me?

6:45 p.m.

I am going to go to the same people and especially when there are a lot of people there and they are going to vote. I am making reference to all of this because when one listens and appreciates the commencing statements of the maker of the Statement, one will understand that there needs to be a time for us to have some sort of harmony which should not be on partisan lines. The harmony should be on the fact that we are clearing all our drains of filth. We are ensuring that drains are constructed so that when it rains, there will not be floods in Weija; there will not be floods in Ablekuma North; there will not be floods—

Mr Speaker, if we can take the bull by the horn and call the shots of the SDG 11 that talks about a safe, inclusive and resilient environment. When we all come together, we can deliver and leave politics out of keeping our environment clean.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to thank the maker of this Statement again and to ask your good self that this should be escalated.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, I was going to direct that this Statement is forwarded to you so that you help us in implementing some of these recommendations.

So, I do not think you need another time to expatiate on it.

Mr Ahmed Ibrahim (NDC — Banda): Mr Speaker, you know I am always with you, and how we think alike. As for the *Hansard*, posterity will use it as a research material and my input will not be seen, so spare me just two minutes.

Mr Speaker, let me commend wholeheartedly the Hon Minority Chief Whip for the extensive work and the Statement that he has presented on the Floor. Like I said, this is the essence of parliamentary Statements where matters of critical public importance are brought on the Floor to catch the attention of policymakers like myself where decisions have to be made for nation building. Therefore, it will not be out of place when the Statement is referred to the Joint Committees on Local Government and Rural Development, and Environment, Labour Relations and Pensions for actions to be taken.

Mr Speaker, all what was said here are issues that are on my heart. He spoke on public transport and that is Bus Rapid Transit (BRT) system which is managed by the Greater Accra and Passenger Transport Executive (GAPTE). When I took office, it was one area I checked. Between 2010 and 2014, about 200 buses were procured by the first Mahama Administration and as at 2025 not all of them were roadworthy and they could not procure even a single additional one to the fleet. The question is, are we being productive or is that how we build a country? The essence of the World Bank giving us those facilities in 2014 to procure those buses was to make sure that we built upon it.

Mr Speaker, I was not old enough when the Omnibus Services Authority

(OSA), State Transport Corporation (STC) and City Express collapsed. We had someone like Nuamah Donkor to revamp STC. So, I would not sit down for the Bus Rapid Transport system to also collapse. What I did was ask the director, why he could not procure additional coaches over the 10 years, whether he would do that if it were his private asset, and if he was fit to occupy the position? Now they have about 135. We had to replace him. And because of that, the new director also knows that he will be changed if he is not able to buy more.

So, I was very happy when my Colleague said we should buy some of the electric buses to augment the existing ones. Mr Speaker, I want the *Hansard*—and a copy will be given to the director and all other heads to read and see the recommendations and what they can do to help implement them, start doing it. This is how countries are grown.

Mr Speaker, the beauty of places like East Legon and Sakumono Estate lies in the trees that are planted there. But if you go to East Legon now, it has outlived its name. Now there are containers in East Legon. It is now a pale shadow of itself. So, when my Colleague talks of greening the cities and the streets—Mr Speaker, I believe as I speak, the people of East Legon are watching and listening. Coming to the very place that we are now, during the Green Ghana Day, the Rt

Hon Speaker, supported by you, led Leadership of the House to plant trees in front of the bank in the Job 600 Building. I am proud to say that the tree that I planted is there. The tree that the Rt Hon Speaker planted is there, and when you see them, sometimes you smile. This is how we should green our country. However, when you take the Ceremonial Gates, almost all the trees that were planted there are old. Some were even felled by the rains last year. Have they been replaced, or should we just sit and wait for the rest to fall for the place to become bare? This is a lesson to all of us.

Mr Speaker, people are now running from East Legon to Airport Hills, because at Airport Hills there is a green belt and the environment is green. And I believe there are some characters who will bring containers the moment they move there.

Mr Speaker, the reason the Land Use and Spatial Planning Act, 2016 (Act 925) was passed, was to make sure that we implement it. But how many specialists do we have in the 261 Metropolitan Municipal and District Assemblies? We have only 10 professionals. The Office of the Head of Local Government Services goes for financial clearance to recruit professionals. Once they get the clearance, they recruit social scientists. So, the Ministry of Local Government,

Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, does not have the needed professionals to be able to embark on spatial planning and implement those reports. Out of 36,000 local government staff, we have only 10 spatial planners. Where will we post them? These are the problems. The academia is talking; theorists are talking. They are saying that I should bring a Bill in which spatial planners and the social planners will be brought together. Once we do that, if care is not taken, it will result in challenges.

So on that note, Mr Speaker, we may move to implement the policies and recommendations that are given. But my call is that having commended the maker of the Statement, I will need your support. You are mentioning Adjiri Blankson—

Mr Speaker, yesterday, I met the Norwegian in Ambassador and they have signed an agreement with us. They have selected 10 cities: Tamale, Wenchi, Techiman, Takoradi, and the rest. We are embarking on the Ghana Secondary Cities Support Programme in those cities. People will ask me about the criteria used in selecting those cities. I must be backed by law before I can do that.

Mr Speaker, I need the support of the House. A great disservice was done to the Ministry. The House passed the formula for the disbursement of the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF). The House knows that the

Administrator does come under my jurisdiction, but it failed to allocate even GH¢1.00 to the Ministry. The Ministry is with zero funding from the DACF.

6.55 p.m.

So how can they be asking me some of those things? My call and plea is that, at least, as a former Leader, who has metamorphosed to become a Minister, when we are approving the 2026 formula, let us find a way, after the 80 per cent, to allocate at least one per cent, for greening Ghana.

I will get in touch with my Colleague, the Minister for Education. If we cannot do anything at all, we must plant trees in the new schools that are built.

The Singaporean strategy—They use caning. As I speak, if one goes to litter in Singapore, they will be caned. If one cuts a tree, they will be caned. So, this Statement will be translated into policy and I believe, my Colleague, the environmentalist, Hon Frank Annoh-Dompreh—Now, his Friend has become a Minister. He will support him in implementing it.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. May God bless you. May you live long.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: And you did not include Fomena Constituency.

Mr Ibrahim: Once 2026 allocation comes, Fomena will be catered for.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a very important Statement. We live in a country where everybody wants to do what pleases them. Once what they have decided to do pleases them, that is all. Whether it conforms to the law, the rules, or the regulations is immaterial. And that calls for our Leadership. It appears from the local to the national. We do not have the right and required leadership. Because if we had the leadership, nobody would be allowed to do what pleases them.

And for me, that is the crux of the matter. We will do all the planning; we will do everything. If we do not have the right leadership, it will come to nought. So, this Statement is very important. And as we said earlier, I direct that we transfer it to the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs and the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology. Incidentally, the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs is here, so he can take it on board in whatever policies they will be drafting.

I thank the makers of the Statement, Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe and Hon Annoh-Dompreh. We bring Statement time to a close. Before we adjourn the House, I would indulge you to allow me to lay Papers. So, we now move into Public Business, which is the item numbered 9—Presentations of Papers. Then we bring today's proceedings to a close.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Leader, may you give us an indication? The Speaker has mentioned the Business to be taken. But who is taking the Business? Who is laying the Paper? Where is the Chairman? The Chairman is not here.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The Chairman is not even around.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We have no problem. If we have any members of the Committee, or do they want to make an application to do it?

Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I am actually not aware that these Reports are ready and I cannot spot any of the Committee Members here.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So then, let us take the item numbered 10. I am told that it is also not ready. Yes?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, as the Vice Chairman of the Committee, I can say that our Report is not ready. So, I do not think we can lay it today. We had a discussion with the Deputy Minister. We wanted him to come and lay the Paper, but there are some issues, so we can do that tomorrow.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, I am not dragging it. But for the item numbered 9, I can agree with not laying the item numbered 9(i), but (ii)

and (iii) are just Annual Reports. So, I think they should lay the Annual Report, but not the Bill. So that the Report can be referred.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, I am told the Finance Committee has not actually indicated that they have finished. But I wonder how it appeared on the *Order Paper*. So, I think we will hold on to that. So that tomorrow, or any time they are ready, we lay them.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I think we will push them for tomorrow.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: If they will be ready tomorrow, that will be fine.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: I mean, when they are ready, we can lay them, but not today. So, my suggestion was for us to move for the proceedings to be adjourned.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hold on. Before you move any Motion, let me take this announcement.

Hon Members, I wish to inform the House that Parliament will host the biannual general meeting of the African Parliamentarians Network Against Corruption (APNAC) under the theme, “Repositioning APNAC in the Fight Against Corruption: Overcoming Current and Emerging Challenges.” The biannual general meeting will take place from Thursday, 6th November to Sunday, 9th November, 2025, at the Alisa Hotel, North Ridge, Accra.

This important continental gathering will bring together parliamentarians from across Africa to deliberate and strategise to strengthen the role of parliaments in promoting transparency, accountability and integrity in governance. It will also provide a platform for sharing experiences, fostering collaboration and developing innovative approaches to address both current and emerging corruption-related challenges, which continues to be the major threat to our quest for shared growth and inclusive development. The Speaker will officially open the conference on the 7th November, 2025.

I encourage Hon Members, particularly the members of the Ghana APNAC National Chapter, to take a keen interest in this significant event and to participate actively in the proceedings. I thank you for your attention.

Hon Members, I think the time is beyond 7 p.m. We have gone past five hours in the Chamber; therefore, you are obviously in my hands. So, I will go ahead to adjourn the House.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 7:05 p.m. till Wednesday, 5th November 2025 at 2:00 p.m.

